

I Visited My Wife's Hometown ...And Found Her Hidden Life

A Hot Past Story: Book One



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Chapter One

Chapter 1

The crisp stroke of my brush against the wall was interrupted by a sharp knocking at the front door. I froze, white-coloured droplets spattering the old newspaper I'd haphazardly spread across the floor. Glancing at my bare wrist reminded me I'd forgone my watch - an unconscious habit whenever I lost myself in the rhythm of painting.

"Just a moment!" I called out, carefully setting aside my brush. Hopefully, it wasn't the neighbours again, ready with another noise complaint because I was playing my usual favourite rock mixtape.

Pulling open the door, I was surprised to find Lisa's father Wayne standing on the doorstep, his weathered face wreathed in an uneasy smile.

"Wayne? I wasn't expecting you..." I ushered my father-in-law inside, suddenly self-conscious of my paint-splattered t-shirt and bare feet. "Is everything alright?"

He gave an awkward half-shrug as he stepped into the hallway. "I was actually hoping to catch Lisa. Tried ringing her mobile but no answer, as usual. Is she working away again?"

I felt my chest tighten slightly at the reminder of Lisa's current overseas absence. "She's still in Bangladesh for another fortnight at least. They extended her consultancy with the development project."

Disappointment flickered across Wayne's face before he could mask it. He opened his mouth to respond, but I had already turned back towards the lounge, calling over my shoulder.

"I'll put the kettle on. Make yourself at home. I'll bring us both a brew..."

I led him into our cramped but sunny living room. Streaks of paint streaked the drop cloths and newspaper covering the bare floors, the lingering scent of turpentine and fresh plaster hanging in the air. The redecoration of the house was my project before Lisa returned home, a little surprise renovation to breathe new life into the space.

Wayne settled onto the tattered sheet protecting the floral sofa, brushing aside a scatter of well-thumbed paperbacks and decorating magazines. At

sixty-five, he still carried himself with the sturdy, no-nonsense air of his younger years working the construction sites. However, the slump of his shoulders and mournful downturn of his mouth hinted at the weariness that had taken root since the passing of his beloved second wife, Alice, five years earlier.

"It's a bit last minute, I know," he began, leaning forward to take the cup of coffee that I'd made him as I returned from the kitchen. "But Joy's only gone and got herself engaged to that Marcus lad she's been seeing. The wedding's booked for next weekend up in Barnesfield."

Joy was one of Lisa's younger cousins, the bright, spirited daughter of Wayne's sister Nancy. I vaguely recalled Lisa mentioning this Marcus name in passing during one of her infrequent calls home recently.

"They haven't been dating long," I murmured, impossibly trying to recall the last time I'd actually seen Joy in person. Three years ago? Four?

Wayne huffed out a mirthless chuckle, scrubbing a calloused hand over his lined face. "You're telling me. That girl's always been an impulsive one. I love her dearly but she's never been able to slow down and think things through." There was a wistful fondness in his tone, one I recognized from Lisa whenever she spoke of her late mother, Wayne's first wife.

"That's just how some people are," I commented, sitting down on the chair opposite him,

"Which is why I'd hoped to have Lisa there, you know?" Wayne continued with a slight shake of his head. "She's got a smart head on her shoulders, maybe could have talked some sense into Joy before she goes making any rash decisions."

The words stuck in my throat as I opened my mouth to remind him of Lisa's prolonged absence. Of course, he knew, but the futile hope lingering in his faded blue eyes rendered me temporarily speechless. With an inward pang, I was struck by how achingly lonely he must feel in their big, empty house. I'd never actually been there, even though Lisa and I had been married for four years now, but she always described it that way.

"Lisa isn't due back for another couple of weeks," I said slowly. "Rash decisions? You mean like getting pregnant or something?"

"Exactly." Wayne nodded, then after an awkward pause, he gathered himself, forcing a tight smile that didn't reach his eyes.

"Well, if my Lisa-bear can't make it, at least someone from the family ought to be there, eh? You'll come, won't you, James? For Joy's sake, and to

keep an old man company."

I shifted uncomfortably on the dustsheet-covered armchair, suddenly aware of Wayne's expectant gaze across the cluttered coffee table. Attending Joy's hastily planned wedding in Lisa's hometown was the last thing I'd anticipated for my weekend. I knew next to nothing about Lisa's old stomping grounds beyond the dismissive curls of her lip whenever conversation veered towards her roots.

"I'll...have to think about it," I hedged, rubbing my palms against my paint-smudged thighs. "It's quite a trek up to Barnesfield."

He made a noncommittal grunt, neither confirming nor denying the substantial distance between our cosy London terrace and the faded, industrial town in the North West that Lisa fled over a decade ago. In her rare, unguarded moments, I'd pieced together that she harboured a deep disdain for her humble beginnings - the rundown estates, the pervasive smell of the shipyards, and small-town narrowmindedness.

Lisa never spoke of those formative years unless pressed, always deflecting with a derisive shake of her head. "Ancient history, that place. There's no point in dredging up the past when we've both moved on to so much better."

But the way Wayne's rheumy eyes clouded over now told a different story. For him, no doubt, those northern backstreets still echoed with the ghosts of happier times before his two wives' untimely passings. Before Lisa's meteoric rise from the ashes of her mother's death propelled her into a whirlwind life of global adventures, determined to leave the grief and grit of her childhood behind.

However, before Wayne could respond, the sound of the front door opening was followed by a rich, sultry voice from the hallway, startling me. I must have left the front door open.

"Wayne? You in here, love?"

My breath caught in my throat as a stunningly attractive woman swept into the living room, all tanned limbs and tousled chestnut curls. She couldn't have been much older than Lisa, the silk blouse and skinny jeans combo hugging her lithe figure in all the right ways. A heavy pendant rested temptingly against the swell of her cleavage.

"Ah, there you are!" She flashed me a warm, radiant smile. "I'm guessing you must be the famous James that Wayne's always going on about."

Flustered, I scrambled to my feet as Wayne heaved himself up from the sofa with a grunt.

"James, this is Della, my...well, my partner, I suppose you could say." There was an unmistakable mix of pride and awkwardness in his gruff tones as he made the introduction, almost as if testing how the unfamiliar word sounded on his lips.

Della rolled her pretty brown eyes good-naturedly and nudged him with her hip. "Wife's the term you're looking for, you daft old dog."

My brows hiked upwards as realization set in. Wife? Since when did Wayne have a third spouse beyond the saintly spectre of his two late wives?

"We've only been married a month," Della said conspiratorially as if reading the stunned question in my expression. With a warm laugh, she sidled up to Wayne's side and looped an arm through the crook of his elbow. "I thought an old codger like this one needed someone to keep him in line."

Her new husband cleared his throat, the tips of his ears pinkening slightly under Della's teasing gaze. "Right, well, as I was saying before Della so rudely interrupted," He shot her a mock-stern look that she answered with an unrepentant grin. "We'd got it into our heads to have a proper wedding ceremony, but then this one couldn't be bothered with all the fuss and bother." He jerked his thumb in Della's direction with a resigned chuckle. "So we just did it quick and quiet - we signed the papers with Nancy as our witness and had done with it."

My brows rose incredulously at the casual mention of Lisa's aunt Nancy. From what I knew about her, Nancy was a sort of family matriarch. Nothing happened in Lisa's family without Nancy's say-so. She'd been quite overbearing at our own wedding as I was all too happy to not have much to do with her since. But before I could inquire further about their wedding, wondering if Lisa knew anything at all about it, Della had extricated herself from Wayne's arm and was closing the distance between us with a saunter in her hip.

"I'd been looking forward to finally meeting the famous Lisa to celebrate." Her voice dropped into a silky-rich timbre, all too aware of the effect she had as she toyed idly with the pendant nestled between her breasts. "You'll have to do for now, I suppose."

I felt heat prickling along the back of my neck as she held my gaze for a beat too long, her full lips curved into a secret smile. Della was clearly a woman well-versed in charming men, deploying an intoxicating mixture of

blatant flirtation and that particular brand of confidence that comes from knowing your own appeal. It was all too obvious how she'd charmed Wayne but what was he thinking, marrying a woman so much younger than him?

Shifting awkwardly, I cleared my throat and replied, "Ah, right, well Lisa's away for work at the moment. Development consultancy in Bangladesh for another couple weeks, unfortunately."

Della's perfectly sculpted brows hiked upwards as she turned to face Wayne. "Is that so? Well then, we have to make sure her dashing hubby attends the wedding to represent the family in her place."

Before I could protest, she'd sidled up alongside me, slipping one arm through the crook of my elbow in a mirror of how she'd cosied up to Wayne earlier. The warmth and fragrant jasmine scent of her body brushing against mine made it maddeningly difficult to summon a coherent argument.

"Go on, say you'll go," she cajoled in a too innocent tone that betrayed her underlying intent. "I'll even make it worth your while..." She punctuated the suggestion with a fleeting stroke along my forearm, raising all the tiny hairs in its wake.

Swallowing hard against the sudden dryness in my throat, I found myself nodding faintly, momentarily captive to Della's bewitching ways. Wayne's rumbling chuckle from across the room indicated I wasn't the first man to succumb to her particular brand of persuasion.

"That's settled then!" Della proclaimed brightly, extracting her arm from mine as quickly as she'd hooked it. She moved to reclaim her position tucked against Wayne's side, leaving the imprint of her touch burning on my skin like a phantom caress.

I had the distinct feeling I'd just been well and truly played by Wayne's new wife. Though whether I was more shaken, intrigued, or simply bowled over by her forwardness, I couldn't quite decide.

Wayne settled back against the sofa cushions with a thoughtful furrow in his brow. "You know, it might actually do you some good to take a trip up to Barnesfield, James." He ran a hand over his thinning hair before continuing in that familiar world-weary rasp. "You'll get a look at where your Lisa grew up, the place she's always been so ashamed of."

I started to protest, but Wayne raised his palm to stop me. "No, no, don't try denying it, lad. I know my Lisa better than anyone. She's been running from her roots since the day she could sprint out of the town."

There was a melancholic resignation in his faded blue eyes that doused the flicker of indignation rising in my chest. As much as I wanted to leap to Lisa's defence, I couldn't rightly dismiss the implication that she'd deliberately kept me apart from that side of her life ever since we met.

"It's not that she's embarrassed, per se," I found myself arguing, more for my own benefit than Wayne's. "She's just... uncomfortable rehashing the past? She had it pretty rough after her mum passed."

A rueful snort escaped Wayne at that. "Maybe. More's the pity. Lisa had the whole world at her feet before Helen's passing knocked a big bloody hole through all our lives." He shook his head slowly. "Changed her, it did. Happy-go-lucky lass turned sullen and sharp overnight. Too much for me to handle."

I couldn't help but wince inwardly at the unvarnished truth in his words. For all that Lisa exuded infectious laughter and charm to the outside world, I'd always detected an undercurrent of melancholy woven through her core. An impenetrable sadness she veiled with teasing grins and mercurial mood shifts whenever the conversation delved too deep.

"Plus," Wayne added, tilting his head in thought, "With all the other goings on and rumours-"

Della, who had remained a watchful sentinel at Wayne's side through our exchange, chose that moment to interject in her rich panged tones.

"Well, maybe some time back home surrounded by family is just what the poor love needs, hmm?" She cocked her head meaningfully. "Could be just the thing to finally put some of those old ghosts to rest. You should try to get hold of her. See if she can't get back from Bangla... wherever you said she is, in time."

It was on the tip of my tongue to dismiss her unsolicited psychoanalysis when Wayne gave a decisive nod of agreement. "She's right, you know. The fact is, I need you there, James. For me...but for Lisa too, whether she'd ever admit it or not."

What was he referring to? The pleading desperation etched into the crevices around his mouth struck something inside me. Perhaps he had a point - all these years of avoiding the subject of her past had clearly left unhealed wounds festering. With a resigned exhalation, I nodded.

"Alright, you've twisted my arm." I mustered a wry smile, determined not to let the unexpected melancholy seep into my words. "When's this

wedding, then? May as well hear all the gory details if I'm meant to be the token representative."

As Wayne and Della began to tell me all about the plans for Joy's big day, Lisa's father pulling a creased invitation from his back pocket with the date and venue details, I began to wonder if this might work out to be a good thing. He was right. It would be helpful for me to see Lisa's old hometown. It might help me to understand her more and shed some light on why she was so reluctant to talk about her past.

What I didn't know right then, is that what I was about to learn there would change everything I thought I knew about Lisa and shake our marriage to its very core.

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Chapter Two

Chapter 2

The drive north to Barnesfield stretched on for endless miles, the grey monotony of the motorway lulling me into a pensive silence. I drummed my fingers against the steering wheel, stealing glances at my phone nestled in the cupholder, willing it to spring to life with a call or message from Lisa.

But the device remained stubbornly dark and silent, just as it had been for the past few days since Wayne's unexpected visit. I'd tried again and again to reach my wife, sending texts and sending emails, all to no avail. Like often happened when she worked abroad, it was as if she had simply vanished into the ether, unreachable in the remote corners of Bangladesh where her work had taken her.

A frown creased my brow as I recalled the uncharacteristic panic that had flashed across Lisa's features when I'd suggested we visit her hometown, back when we first met. She'd refused, insisting that we keep our distance to avoid getting tangled up in the complexities of her family and the run-down town she used to call home. At the time, I'd been bewildered by her vehement reaction, so unlike the poised, unflappable woman I thought I knew.

Now, as the miles ticked by and I drew closer to the gritty industrial town of Della and Wayne's origins, a niggling sense of unease began to take root. Maybe I was about to find out what was it about this place—about Lisa's family—that had her so determined to keep me at arm's length all these years.

I also couldn't help but feel a twinge of hurt and resentment. After six years together and four years of marriage, I thought Lisa and I had built a foundation of absolute trust and honesty but at times I got a paranoid sense that there might be deep-seated secrets she had been concealing, shadows from her past that she refused to confront, even with me.

I was nervous about meeting her family too. I'd met Wayne before, her half-sister, Amy and her childhood best friend, Erica, at our wedding in

Bermuda. The trip to the beautiful Caribbean island had seemed like the perfect fairytale, a chance to start anew and leave the baggage of her upbringing behind. I'd met Joy too, the cousin that was getting married, when she had visited us once in London. But now, as I reluctantly made this journey on behalf of her, I wondered if choosing somewhere so exotic for our wedding had also been a way of avoiding having the rest of her family there, so I couldn't meet them.

Wayne called to make sure I was on my way and invited me for dinner with him and Della that evening but I told him I wouldn't be there until late. They had told me I could stay over at their place, but I'd booked a hotel for a couple of nights, not wanting to impose. The old man seemed offended, which I'd expected, but Della told him to stop being overpowering.

"It's a big deal that James is finally visiting us," I'd heard her tell him on the phone. "Let him do it his way. You don't want to make him feel uncomfortable or like a burden."

Wayne had grunted his understanding and accepted it and now that I was making the long journey along the northern English motorways, I was glad I'd stuck to my decision. This trip was nerve-racking enough without the anxiety of sleeping in someone else's house, even if they were my in-laws.

A couple of hours later, the sun dipped below the horizon, casting Barnesfield in a warm, golden glow as I sat alone in my hotel room, my phone feeling increasingly heavy in my hand. The number of attempts I'd made to reach Lisa had long been lost to the relentless cycle of texts, calls, and even a couple more emails, all met with the echoing void of silence.

I let out a weary exhale, running a hand through my hair as I gazed at the gritty industrial town before me. It was a stark contrast to the lively, cosmopolitan vibe of our London suburb. Here, the world seemed made of faded working-class brick, rusting shipyard cranes, and an all-encompassing air of melancholy. It made sense why Lisa had never looked back.

Just as I was about to call it a night, my phone burst to life, vibrating with an urgency that made my heart leap. Lisa's smiling face lit up the screen when I answered, that familiar megawatt grin that always seemed to light up everything around her.

"Hey, you," she purred, her voice a warm contralto that sent that familiar happy buzz through my body. "I'm sorry that I've been so bloody hard to reach. Work's been mad, and the signal here is a nightmare. We're on the

edge of the jungle. The nearest town with any sort of internet is a five-hour trip. I can't even access my emails or messages."

The knot of tension in my shoulders began to loosen at the sound of her voice. "It's alright. I'm just happy you called back." I hesitated for a moment, wondering how to tell her where I was.

"I don't have long," she said, just as I was just about to tell her where I was. I'd switched the light off, so all that was visible was my face and the pillow beneath my head, lit by the glow from the phone screen. "We're on a temporary satellite link but it'll be closed down in ten minutes or so."

"Ah," I nodded, understanding. This wasn't unusual. "I better hurry and tell you what's been going on while you've been away then."

"I don't want to talk boring stuff," she interrupted me, her full lips curving at the edges into a mysterious grin. She looked gorgeous, despite her face being covered in a light sheen of sweat and her damp-looking auburn hair appearing almost dark brown in the low light of the dimly lit hotel room she seemed to be in. "I miss you. I love you. I can't wait to come home and have mad sex with you. I've been tired. The nights here are so hot and humid but tonight I'm kind of horny."

"I miss you too," I chuckled, my cock twitching in the shorts I was wearing in bed as she shrugged off the t-shirt she was wearing, revealing her large, curvy breasts. Lisa liked sex. Our relationship had been slow to begin with in that department, but after six months of dating, she opened up and I discovered what a devil she was between the sheets. We'd never looked back since. Our sex life was healthy and regular. When she was home, we often did it three or four times a week at least. "But, Lisa, I really need to tell you—"

"Tell me afterwards," she insisted, interrupting me again, then giggling and placing the camera further away so I could see the entirety of her naked body. She spread her thighs to show me the triangle of dark hair between her legs—she hadn't been able to shave recently, clearly—and then she slipped a finger into herself, moaning softly. "I'm horny, James. Show me your cock. Play with it for me."

"But... Lisa, I need to tell you—"

"Mmm, fuck. That feels so good," she purred as she masturbated on the screen in front of me. "James, it's the middle of the night here. I need to orgasm and sleep. Play with your dick for me until I cum. Then you can tell me whatever's so important."

“Okay. Fine,” I sighed. I was horny myself, I realized, my dick stiff beneath the bed covers from watching my wife finger herself. I pushed the covers down and pulled my cock out, stroking it while positioning my phone so she could see.

“Are you missing me?” she moaned, gazing at the image on her screen as she rubbed her clit. “Tell me you’re missing my tits and pussy, James.”

“Of course I am,” I replied softly, watching her fingers work her clit, her hips moving up and down, and then noting how she trembled as her arousal built beneath her touch. “I can’t wait for you to come home. This trip seems to be taking forever.”

“Does my pussy look good?”

“Mmm,” I sighed. It did. She plunged two fingers into herself, bucking her hips forward. “I wish you were here so we could fuck.”

“Me too,” Lisa replied, her voice barely audible, then she tensed, her fingers rubbing her clit fast now. “Fuck, I’m going to cum. Wank off, James. I want you to cum too.”

I stroked my cock hard and fast but I wasn’t quite there yet. Lisa came, the sound of her orgasm so loud through my phone speakers that I hurried to reduce the volume in case the people in the room next door heard.

“Oh... I needed that,” she giggled after a moment, picking the phone up again and moving it closer to her face. “Did you cum?”

“Yes,” I lied, pulling my phone back to my own face so she couldn’t see. “That was fun.”

As I said that, because of the change of angle, the headboard to the bed was visible and her expression shifted, a frown marring her features. “Where are you? That doesn’t look like our bed. What’s going on?”

“It’s not,” I replied. “That’s what I was trying to tell you.”

Taking a deep breath, I spilled the details about Wayne’s unexpected visit, the last-minute wedding invitation, and my somewhat reluctant agreement to attend in her place.

Her reaction was swift and sharp, a complete turnaround from the warmth of moments ago. “You’re *there*? In Barnesfield?” she snapped, her blue eyes narrowing.

“Yes,” I replied, confusion and concern threading through my voice. “Your dad... and his new bride... They wouldn’t take no for an answer.”

“I need to meet this new bride of his,” Lisa said, her voice as cold as steel. “You shouldn’t have gone without checking with me first.”

“I’ve been trying to get hold of you non-stop,” I shrugged. “Wayne’s called me twice since to make sure I was coming. How could I say no? Plus... I thought it might be good to... you know, finally, see where you grew up. I know you’re embarrassed about where you come from, but I won’t judge, you should know that by now. Your dad said Barnesfield really isn’t that bad.”

The mention of her father only seemed to ignite her anger further. “And just what else did my dear old dad say, precisely?” she pressed, her tone icy.

I tried to reassure her, explaining Wayne’s vague concerns about her reluctance to share her past with me and his belief that understanding her roots might help me comprehend her better.

She scoffed, visibly frustrated. “Unbelievable. He just can’t keep his nose out of my life, can he?”

I attempted to calm her, to reason with her, but she cut me off. “No, James. You need to listen to me,” she insisted, her voice hard. “Go home. Tell them you’re sick or something.”

Her insistence puzzled me, and I couldn’t hide my confusion. “But why? What are you hiding?”

“I’m not hiding anything.” Lisa sighed, closing her eyes for a moment. “Look... Fine. You’ve made the trip north, I guess you have to see this through but listen to me... My family don’t like me. They resent me for leaving. Shit happened. I fell out with my aunt, we argued. We never got on during the good times, so... if any of them speak to you... Whatever nonsense they try to fill your head with, you need to ignore it. All of it. Understand?”

“Nonsense?” I questioned. “What kind of nonsense?”

Lisa’s response was firm, her lips a thin line of resolve. “Barnesfield is a small town. Everyone knows everyone’s business. That’s why I got out of there. My two ex-boyfriends were... well, one was a psycho and the other one was a total sap but had a big mouth. I know they’ll have said shit about me after I left.”

“I don’t care,” I started to say but she cut me off.

“I’m running out of time. It’s just that... Digging into my past won’t end well, James. Just do your best to stay away from my family, from all of it, then go home as soon as you can, okay? I’ve made a new life with you in London. That’s my life now. Not Barnesfield.”

Her plea, so full of raw vulnerability, tugged at my heart. “Alright. I promise I’ll head home as soon as I can after the wedding and I’ll try to avoid your evil aunt and the rest of them,” I found myself saying, even as a part of me rebelled at the thought of leaving her secrets unexplored. Then I tried to lighten the mood by making a joke. “Hey, while in town I might even meet that old school friend of yours. What did you call her again? Slutty Sally?”

She seemed to relax slightly, a shadow of a smile flickering across her face. “Slutty Sally left town around the same time I did. She met a guy and moved away. Sorry to disappoint you.”

“She’s the one that screwed her university lecturer and got into a whole load of trouble, right?”

“She screwed everyone in Barnesfield,” Lisa nodded. “But forget about her. She’s not around any more, however, I know someone who is and can take care of you.”

“Yeah?” I grinned. “Is she slutty too?”

“No,” Lisa rolled her eyes. “But yeah, I’ve had an idea. I have a couple more minutes of signal and I need to make a call before it runs out, so I have to go—but I’ll be home soon. We’ll talk then, okay? Keep any questions, including ones about Sally, to yourself until I get back and I’ll tell you all about my past when I’m home, if you really want to know, okay?”

“Okay,” I echoed, though as I hung up, a heavy sense of foreboding settled over me. Her desperate plea to avoid her past, and her family, left me with more questions than answers. What was so dreadful about her history that she feared my discovering it?

As I looked out over the dimming lights of Barnesfield, I couldn’t shake the feeling that whatever Lisa was hiding, it was buried deep within the heart of this town. And despite my promise, a part of me knew that I couldn’t let it go. Not yet.

Chapter Three

Chapter 3

The dawn in Barnesfield broke with a hesitant light as if the sun itself was reluctant to illuminate the industrial town that Lisa had so eagerly left behind. After a restless night spent in the impersonal hotel room, wrestling with the echoes of Lisa's plea and the shadows of unanswered questions, I descended to the breakfast hall, where the scent of strong coffee promised a semblance of normality.

As I lingered over the last of my coffee, pondering the day ahead, a familiar figure approached my table. "James?" she asked, though it was clear from her warm, knowing smile that she needed no confirmation.

"Erica," I greeted, standing to offer a handshake that she bypassed for a friendly hug. "Now I know who Lisa had to call last night after she hung up on me."

"Yeah, she was worried about you navigating the family minefield alone," Erica said, her voice rich with amusement as we exited the hotel. "So she sent me to intercept you and be your guide. Or bodyguard, depending on how you look at it."

Erica was pretty, the same age as Lisa but curvier, with curly honey-coloured hair that bounced on her shoulders. I'd met her a couple of times over the years when she'd visited us in London.

"Do you want breakfast?" I said, offering her a seat next to me.

"I've already eaten," she smiled. "And I'm on a diet. Trying to be good, know you? So, what time does this wedding from hell start?"

Why she was on a diet, I didn't know. She was curvy but in proportion. Her floral summer dress fitted her well, the top buttons undone to show a pleasant amount of pale, creamy cleavage.

We talked and the easy banter lightened the weight on my shoulders as I finished eating and then, as we walked toward the church. Erica shared snippets of Lisa's childhood, painting a picture of a vibrant, if complicated, past. Her mother's death when she was young had affected her deeply, something I already knew and appreciated but the stories made Lisa seem

both closer and farther away; a contradiction made flesh in the form of the woman I loved.

The church loomed ahead, its modest spire a beacon in the subdued morning. Erica's presence by my side was a steady reminder of Lisa's unseen hand guiding me through this day. As we entered, the hum of gathered guests and the fragrance of fresh flowers enveloped us, a stark contrast to the steel and concrete heart of Barnesfield.

Wayne spotted us from across the room, his face breaking into a wide smile as he made his way over. "James, you made it," he said, his handshake firm, his welcome genuine.

"I wouldn't miss it," I replied, the warmth of the greeting easing some of my trepidation about the day ahead.

Then the old man's eyes drifted to the woman by my side. "And Erica, always a pleasure, I'm guessing Lisa sent you to look after James here."

"Something like that," Lisa's best friend replied dryly. "How's Joy doing?"

"Nervous as a long-tailed cat in a room full of rocking chairs," Wayne chuckled, his eyes twinkling with affection. "But ready. Thanks for coming. Means a lot, especially to her."

I nodded, about to ask him more, when a voice called out, "Uncle Wayne!" We both turned to see Joy approaching, her bridal gown a cascade of lace and light, her smile bright enough to rival the sun itself. She was blonde and good-looking, her eyes bright blue and her hair sparkling like gold in the light pouring in through the church's stained glass.

"Look at you, beautiful as ever," Wayne said, his voice thick with emotion as he enveloped her in a hug. Joy's eyes flicked to me, and a blush crept up her cheeks.

"Long time no see, James," she said, extending a hand that I shook gently, mindful of her delicate state.

"Indeed. You look stunning," I complimented her, genuinely happy to see her. Joy had always come across as a nice person every time we met.

"Why, thank you," she replied shyly, her smile slowly widening. "Thank you for being here. It... it means a lot, especially with Lisa unable to make it."

The mention of Lisa's name tightened something in my chest, a mix of regret and unresolved questions. "She wishes she could be here," I managed, my voice steady despite the nervousness I was feeling now.

Before more could be said, a woman's voice called out, "Joy, darling, it's time!" prompting a flurry of activity as the bride was whisked away, leaving Wayne, Erica and me in a suddenly quiet space.

As the guests began to take their seats, Wayne leaned in, his voice low. "After the ceremony, there's a reception at the old boat club. You'll come, right? There'll be some folks you should meet. Friends of Lisa's from way back."

His suggestion caught me off guard, a mixture of curiosity and apprehension swirling within. "Of course, I'll be there," I found myself saying, the decision made before I could fully weigh the implications.

The ceremony itself was a blur of vows, smiles, and applause, a celebration of new beginnings against the backdrop of my own search for answers. I saw a tall, statuesque mature woman with jet-black hair who stayed close to Joy. That must be her mother, Lisa's 'evil Aunt' Nancy. And next to her was a broad, stocky but well-groomed man who must be Nancy's husband, Lisa's Uncle Roy. She didn't speak much about him. I didn't know anyone else there apart from Wayne, Della and Erica. Della looked exquisite in a bright red dress that hugged her hips to perfection and a stunning wide-brimmed hat with a rose pinned to the side. She saw me and waved and when Erica glanced at me, I told her who she was.

"Wayne's got married again?" She scratched her chin in thought and shook her head, making her honey curls shimmer in the light. "She's so much younger than him."

"Well played, Wayne," I grinned and Erica giggled.

"Does Lisa know?"

"I told her last night but she didn't seem happy."

"I can imagine," Erica frowned, gazing at the woman in the scarlet dress as the ceremony ended and the crowd began to disperse. As we followed the other guests to the reception, my thoughts were a tangle of anticipation and unease. What was I hoping to uncover among the faces of Lisa's past? And more importantly, was I prepared for the truths that might emerge?

After a short walk, we stepped into the lively atmosphere of the boat club, Erica by my side, the thrum of conversation and music enveloping us. The building itself was a blend of rustic charm and maritime history, its walls adorned with aged photos of boats and seafarers, telling tales of Barnesfield's nautical past. The bar area, bustling with guests eager to celebrate Joy and Marcus's union, became our first stop.

"I'll have a gin and tonic and a beer, please," Erica ordered for us both, her eyes scanning the crowd with an ease born of familiarity. As the bartender busied himself with our drinks, I seized the moment to delve into the heart of my swirling thoughts.

"Erica," I began, leaning closer to be heard over the music, "Lisa... she made me promise not to dig into her past while I'm here. She seemed... scared, almost. You've known her for years. Why would she be so reluctant to let me come here?"

Erica took a deep breath, her gaze lingering on mine for a long moment. "James, Lisa's past here is... it's messy. She's done things she's not proud of, made decisions she thought she'd left behind."

"We all make mistakes when we're younger," I shrugged, "God knows I made plenty. What's so bad about Lisa's that she feels like she's got to keep me away from here?"

The bartender placed our drinks down, and Erica thanked him with a nod, her attention never wavering from our conversation. "She was young, trying to find her way after her mum died. It was a rough time, and, well, she got involved with people and situations that weren't always the best for her."

"Like who?" The names felt heavy on my tongue, their implications darker than I'd anticipated.

Erica's eyes flashed with a complex emotion, a mix of protectiveness and regret. "It's not for me to say. She'll tell you when she's ready. Lisa was trying to cope, to fill the void left by her mum. And people took advantage of that vulnerability."

"Did I hear you say Lisa?" the barman asked, raising an eyebrow. "Lisa Moffatt? You're Erica, right?"

"That's me," Erica nodded, looking at the tall, dark man cautiously. "Do I know you?"

"Tony," he nodded. "You don't remember me, do you? Is Lisa okay? I haven't seen her in years."

"She's fine," I smiled politely at him. "She's Lisa Jones now. I'm her husband, James."

"That's good to hear." The barman exchanged an indecipherable look with Erica. "Tell her I said 'hi'."

As he walked away to serve someone else at the busy bar, I turned to look at Lisa's friend. "Who's he? Someone I should know about?"

"I have no idea," she said, shrugging indifferently while sipping her gin and tonic. "Barnesfield is a small town. Everyone knows-"

"Everyone knows everyone's business," I finished for her, echoing Lisa's words from last night. "That's what Lisa said. And her family... she said they might try to fill my head with nonsense. What kind of thing should I be ignoring, when they say it?"

"I have no idea," Erica sighed, her finger tracing the rim of her glass. "Lisa broke away from the expectations, the limitations of this place. But breaking away comes at a cost. There are resentments, misunderstandings. And yes, there are those in her family who see her leaving as a betrayal."

"So, what should I do? Just smile and nod while they tell tales?"

"Pretty much," Erica replied with a rueful smile. "Listen, but take it with a grain of salt. Remember, Lisa was doing the best she could under tough circumstances. She's not that person anymore. She's with you, in London, building a life she's chosen."

Her words, meant to reassure, instead laid bare the depth of Lisa's struggle, the complexity of her journey from the troubled streets of Barnesfield to the life we shared. "I just wish she'd felt she could tell me all this herself," I murmured, more to myself than to Erica.

"She wanted to protect you from this, from the judgments and the pain," Erica said, her hand briefly squeezing my arm. "But know this, James. Lisa loves you. She's fought hard to be the woman she is today, the woman you love. And that counts for everything."

"That's nice of you to say." I looked at Lisa's childhood friend, her open, honest face, her light green eyes, her honey-coloured ringlets of hair falling to her shoulders. "She's lucky to have you as a friend."

Right then, a commanding presence approached us, instantly altering the atmosphere. The tall, statuesque woman with jet-black hair I had noticed earlier now stood before us, her poise unmistakable. Her sharp features softened only slightly as she focused on me, her expression one of calculated interest.

"James, I presume?" Her voice was as striking as her appearance, carrying a tone that demanded attention. "I'm Nancy, Lisa's aunt. We've never had the pleasure."

Her introduction was laced with a formality that I didn't expect. Her dark brown eyes, cool and assessing, flicked briefly towards Erica, where they

hardened noticeably. "And Erica, I see you're still in the picture," she said, her tone suggesting history and judgment in equal measure.

Beside Nancy stood the big man who I knew was Lisa's uncle. Despite his size, he bore a more approachable manner. "This is my husband, Ron," she introduced, her voice softening fractionally. Ron extended a hand, his eyes crinkling in a friendly manner that didn't quite reach his gaze, which held a flicker of something else—curiosity, perhaps, or an unspoken tension.

"It's nice to finally meet you, James. Lisa's spoken so... little about you," Ron remarked in a deep gravelly tone, then smiled at the joke.

"Nice to meet you both," I smiled, trying not to wince as his strong handshake almost crushed my fingers.

Close by, two other men lingered within earshot, their presence noted but unobtrusive. One, tall with silver hair and an air of businesslike efficiency, observed the exchange with a detached interest that suggested he was accustomed to navigating social waters with ease. The other, shorter with glasses but exuding a debonair charm despite his much older age, offered a smile as if something amused him.

Nancy's attention, however, remained fixed on me, her curiosity unabashed. "So, James, what brings you to our little gathering without Lisa? She's usually so... attached to you, from what I've heard."

Her inquiry, though phrased as casual interest, carried an undercurrent of probing, as if testing the waters for information or reaction. Erica shifted slightly beside me, a silent signal of support, or perhaps a warning of the undercurrents swirling beneath Nancy's seemingly simple question.

Ron, picking up on his wife's line of inquiry, added, "Yes, we were all surprised to hear she wouldn't be joining us. She always seems to enjoy her trips back home."

The two men nearby, previously content to observe, now showed a keener interest, their expressions a blend of amusement and anticipation. It was clear they were well-versed in the dynamics at play, seasoned observers of the family's intricate ballet of relations and resentments.

"I'm here on Lisa's behalf," I started carefully, ignoring what I presumed was sarcasm from Ron. "She's tied up with work abroad. Bangladesh, actually. It's a crucial project for her career."

Nancy's eyebrow arched slightly. "I see. Well, it's a shame she couldn't make it. Family should be a priority, don't you think?"

"With more notice, I'm sure she'd be here," I forced a smile. "When she's away, she's often uncontactable. The downside to working overseas."

"And she works away a lot, I'm told," Ron added. "Several times a year. Which is why she rarely visits us these days."

"That's right."

Nancy folded her arms beneath her large, but firm-looking breasts and considered me, those dark eyes piercing as she looked me up and down.

"Well, I have to say, Lisa has done well for herself," she said finally. "You're a good-looking boy if you don't mind me saying so. I hope you'll spend some time with us before you head back to London. There's a lot we could tell you about Lisa, what she was like growing up. I'm sure you'd find it very interesting."

The two men standing behind Ron both smirked. What was it that people weren't telling me?

"Anyway, we should mingle," Erica said, slipping her arm through mine. "We'll see you later, Nancy."

I was grateful to her as she swept me away, towards the far corner of the boat club. "Thank you," I muttered. "Why were they so weird?"

"It's just how they are," Erica replied but as she was about to say more, a dark-skinned young woman appeared from the crowd and rushed over to us.

"James!" she exclaimed, giving me a hug before I realised who she was. "It's so cool that you made it."

"Hi, Amy," I smiled, genuinely happy to see her. Amy was Lisa's half-sister, mixed race because Alice, Wayne's second wife, had been black.

She took a step back, fiddling with her long, black braids while smiling back at me, then looked over her shoulder, beckoning a tall, good-looking black man to step forward. "This is Dean, my brother. He's not related to Lisa. He's from mum's first marriage, before she married my dad. Dean, this is James."

"Hi, Dean," I said, extending a hand that he stared at for a long, awkward moment before finally accepting the handshake.

"James," he nodded in acknowledgement. "Welcome to Barnesfield and your wife's crazy family. I'm sure she's told you how crazy they all are, right?"

"She might have mentioned it," I replied, giving the lovely Amy, much younger than Lisa, only eighteen or nineteen, a disarming wink.

Again, Erica whisked me away, heading towards an empty table where we sat and she took a long drink of her gin and tonic and sighed loudly.

"What's up?" I asked her, looking out at the crowd, just as they parted in response to the DJ calling out the first dance for the married couple.

"This is more difficult than I thought it would be," she confessed, swirling her drink absentmindedly. "Lisa really dropped me in it last minute."

"Why's that?" I prodded gently, sensing her reluctance to delve deeper into the reasons behind her discomfort.

Erica avoided my gaze, focusing instead on the dance floor where Marcus and Joy were sharing their first dance as a married couple. The tenderness of the moment, their world reduced to the space between them, stood in stark contrast to the complex web of relationships and histories surrounding us. "It's just... complicated," she finally said, her voice barely above a whisper.

The evening wore on, with various family members making their way over to introduce themselves. Each interaction was polite, yet beneath the surface, I could sense the undercurrents of curiosity and, in some cases, barely concealed resentment. Lisa's absence loomed large, her shadow cast over every conversation, every forced smile until, needing a break from the intensity of the party, Erica suddenly stood, excusing herself for some air. "Join me for a smoke?" she asked, though she knew I didn't smoke.

I nodded, grateful for the excuse to escape, even briefly. We made our way outside, the cool night air a welcome relief from the stuffiness of the crowded boat club. The gentle lap of the river against the docks provided a soothing backdrop as we walked in silence, exploring the exterior of the building until we found a secluded spot away from the other guests.

"Dean and Lisa used to be together," she said suddenly, her voice cutting through the silence as she lit her cigarette. "That's why he was... frosty with you."

The revelation caught me off guard, not so much the fact of Lisa's previous relationship, but Dean's identity as part of her past. I wrestled with a mix of emotions, surprise chief among them. Though I couldn't help but notice Dean's race, it was not the fact itself that gave me pause, but rather the realization of how little I knew of Lisa's history.

"Wasn't he like... her step-brother?"

"Not when they were together, no," Erica replied, blowing a blue smoke ring into the cooling night air. "Wayne and Alice married later. As I said, it's complicated."

"And what else should I know?" I found myself asking, the question hanging between us like a challenge.

"I wouldn't even know how or where to begin." Erica's eyes widened as soon as the words escaped her lips. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have said that."

"It's okay," I began but then paused as voices told us that someone else was heading around the side of the boat club. I quickly recognised the sultry tones of Della and took Erica's hand. "Shit. I don't want them thinking we're up to something we shouldn't be, hiding around here."

"Yes," she whispered back, dragging me further around the back of the club into the shadows along the riverbank. "This way."

We hid beneath a wide canopy that covered several small boats, pulled up onto the gangway and watched as Lisa's father and his new wife stumbled drunkenly to where we'd been talking a moment before. Then, to my surprise, Della dropped down to her knees, looking around her for a moment to make sure the coast was clear. Then she unzipped her husband's pants and unable to look away, I saw her pull out his cock.

"Oh, shit." Erica giggled awkwardly and I glanced at her to see her look away, not wanting to watch what was about to happen.

Wayne's cock was small, with a large mushroom head but Della didn't seem to care, stroking him with her hand before taking him in between her full lips and beginning to suck him eagerly.

"That's a good girl," the old man sighed. "Suck it good."

We couldn't move. Erica and I had to wait for a good ten minutes until finally, Wayne put his hands on the back of Della's head, his fingers tangling in her chestnut hair and grunted as he came in her mouth. Then Della stood up and as he put himself away, he said something that changed everything.

"You know, I haven't seen James since he got here," Wayne said, straightening his clothes up, and tucking his shirt back into his trousers. "I hope everything is okay and no one's said anything to him. I told them all to keep their mouths shut."

"Yes, what would he think if he found out that half the men in that club have been inside his perfect wife," Della murmured, wiping her mouth with a tissue before tossing it into the river nearby.

"He'd be broken-hearted, that's what," Wayne replied, taking his wife by the hand and leading her back around the club towards the entrance but before he did, Della turned, looking over her shoulder, straight at where Erica and I were hiding.

And she smiled.

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Chapter Four

Chapter 4

As Wayne and Della disappeared around the corner, their footsteps fading into the night, I remained frozen, the image of Della's knowing smile seared into my mind. Beside me, Erica's breath was shallow, her body tense as if bracing for a storm. My heart pounded with a mix of anger and betrayal, the words Della had casually tossed into the night echoing ominously.

"What did she mean by that?" I asked, the words sharp, my voice barely above a whisper. I couldn't shake the chill that had settled over me, nor the dread that crept up my spine.

Erica didn't answer immediately. She seemed to be searching for the right words, her pale green eyes following the discarded tissue floating past us on the river—Della's tissue, a reminder of what we'd just seen. "She knew we were here," she murmured, as if to herself. "She just did that... said that... deliberately. She wanted you to hear, James. She's trying to cause trouble."

"Maybe it's a good job she did say it," I retorted. "It seems no one else wants to tell me anything."

"James, it's not my place," she finally murmured, her voice heavy with regret.

"Not your place?" My frustration boiled over. "Erica, I think after what we just overheard, I deserve some damn honesty. What is going on? What did she mean by 'half the men in that club'?"

Erica turned to face me, her expression sombre. "It's complicated, James. Lisa... she had a past before you. We all did. But hers was... more tangled."

"Tangled how?" I demanded. The sound of the river seemed to swell around us, drowning out the music pumping out of the boat club as we slowly emerged from the shadows where we'd hidden, taking a few steps around the side of the building.

"She was young, vulnerable. She made choices, some not so great," Erica explained, her voice a blend of defensiveness and pity. "I already told you.

The Lisa you know, the woman you married, she's not that person anymore. She fought hard to move past it."

"But to hear that she—" I couldn't finish the sentence, the implication too painful to voice fully.

Erica reached out, placing a tentative hand on my arm. "People change, James. They grow. What Della said... it was cruel and unnecessary. Lisa's past... it shouldn't define how you see her now."

I shook my head, trying to process the flood of emotions. Betrayal, hurt, confusion—it was all too much. "I need to know, Erica. The truth, all of it."

She sighed, a long and weary sound. "Lisa should be the one to explain everything. But, if you're sure..." Her eyes met mine, filled with a mix of sympathy and resolve. "Let's walk. It's only a matter of time before someone catches us behind here together and makes an assumption."

We walked in silence along the riverbank, the gentle lapping of water against the shore a stark contrast to the turmoil inside me. Every step felt heavier, each breath sharper as I braced myself for what was to come. Erica led me to a secluded bench away from the noise and lights of the boat club. As we sat, the distance from the party seemed to offer not just physical but emotional space to unravel the threads of Lisa's hidden history.

"Lisa was different when she lived here," Erica began, her voice steady despite the weight of the story she was about to tell. "She was dealing with her mother's death, her father's absence. She sought comfort where she could, often in the wrong places, with the wrong people. She got involved with men who didn't have her best interests at heart. Some of them are still around, still part of this community. Some of them are in that party. That's partly why she never wanted to bring you here. She was afraid—afraid of being judged by her past, afraid you'd look at her differently."

"And you? Why didn't you tell me?"

"I wanted to," Erica confessed, "but it wasn't my story to tell. And honestly, I thought it was behind her, that she had moved on so completely that it wouldn't matter anymore."

She lit another cigarette and took a long drag from it, sending another perfect smoke ring into the cooling night air. I watched it dissipate, feeling much like my understanding of Lisa—once solid and substantial, now fading into something intangible.

"Did Lisa sleep with that barman? Tony, wasn't it?" I couldn't mask the sharpness in my voice, my bruised ego pressing for clarity even though part

of me feared the answer.

Erica's gaze lingered on the river, its surface shimmering with moonlight. "I don't know, James," she said after a long pause, her voice non-committal. "Lisa knew a lot of people back then."

"But you don't deny it," I pressed, unable to let it go, needing to anchor my swirling thoughts with facts, however painful.

"I don't," she admitted quietly, her honesty a cold comfort. "But James, it doesn't matter now, does it? None of this changes who she is now."

She was right, of course, but rational thought was drowned out by a chorus of doubt and wounded pride. The smirks and sidelong glances I remembered from the club and the wedding now seemed loaded with hidden meaning, and I felt exposed, foolish—a man who had loved blindly, not seeing the amusement in the eyes of those who watched.

"I need to know," I insisted, my voice low, desperate. I know myself too well. This is going to play on my mind until I know. "Names. Numbers. I need to know who, when, how many... I need the whole truth."

Erica exhaled a cloud of smoke, her expression weary. "James, that's a dark path. What good will it do to dig up the past? You're just drunk and emotional."

But I was resolute, driven by a gnawing need for full disclosure. "Maybe you're right," the edge in my voice betraying my internal turmoil. "But I can't stand it. I just wish she was here to tell me herself."

She took a long drag from her cigarette, light greeneyes assessing me through the haze. Then she flicked the ash from the tip onto the floor and sighed. "Adam and Colin," she finally divulged, her voice resigned. "They were both involved with her. And Dean, which you already know."

"Who?" I questioned, the two names slicing through the air.

"The men with Ron earlier," Erica fidgeted on the wooden bench, pulling her dress down to cover more of her thighs. The night was turning colder, much like my mood. "The two older guys standing behind him and Nancy."

"Anyone else?"

"I can't... I don't remember," she faltered, avoiding my gaze. "I don't keep a diary of everyone that Lisa slept with. You're starting to make me feel uncomfortable."

Frustrated and feeling isolated, I pulled my phone from my pocket and tried to call Lisa, needing to hear her voice, to demand answers directly. But the call wouldn't connect, leaving me further unmoored, adrift in a sea of

unanswered questions. The revelation about Adam and Colin, the two older men who had observed me with unreadable expressions earlier in the evening, now made a cruel kind of sense. Erica's admission, followed by her sudden reticence about any others, hinted at more secrets, more shadows lurking beneath the surface.

"We should go back inside," Erica said, aiming and successfully tossing her cigarette butt into the bin near the bench. "They'll be wondering where you are."

I gazed at the boat club, a short walk down the river. She was right, but facing all of those faces again felt like an insurmountable task. "I can't go back in there, Erica. Not now, not knowing what I know," I admitted, my voice strained with the weight of revelations still settling in.

She looked at me, her pretty eyes earnest in the dim light. "James, I understand it's hard, but you can't just disappear. It would raise too many questions. You need to go back, say your goodbyes. Keep your head high."

Her words, meant to be encouraging, only served to remind me of the facade I would need to maintain. "How can I pretend everything's fine?" I asked, the idea of facing that room full of hidden smirks and unspoken stories churning my stomach.

"Because you have Lisa now. Yes, many men in there might have history with her, but you're the one she chose. They're just jealous," Erica said, her tone firm, almost commanding. "Remember that. She's with you now, not them."

Her logic was sound, even if it did little to ease the turmoil inside me. After a moment's hesitation, I nodded. "Okay, I'll go back in. I'll say goodbye, wish Joy well, and thank them for the invitation. Then I'm out of there."

"That's the spirit," she said with a half-smile. She stood, adjusting the front of her dress, pulling it up where her cleavage was showing a little too much. "Grab one last drink, if it helps. I'll walk you back to the hotel afterwards."

Agreeing to her plan, I followed her back into the warmth and noise of the boat club, the music and laughter now a stark contrast to the cold truths swirling inside me. As we reentered, the shift in my perception was palpable; every glance felt loaded, every laugh a potential jab.

Della caught my eye from across the room, her smile as enigmatic as ever. She toyed with a lock of her chestnut hair, then approached with the

grace of someone oblivious to the turmoil they'd caused, even though I was sure she'd done it deliberately. "Enjoying the party?" Her voice was light, but the undercurrent was undeniable. "You certainly seem to be enjoying Erica's company."

"I am, although it's time for me to head back. Erica has just been telling me about Barnesfield and the history of this place," I explained, forcing a casual tone while watching her closely. She wanted to play games, did she? "It's a shame Lisa couldn't be here tonight but it seems like you've been keeping Wayne quite... entertained in her absence."

Her deep brown eyes flickered with a mix of amusement and surprise, clearly catching the subtext of my words. "You don't know me very well yet but if you did, you'd know that I'm someone who likes to make people happy," she replied smoothly, her voice tinged with a hint of mischief. "You do need to get to know your family better."

I nodded, noting the careful choice of her words. "Well, you seem to know how to make Wayne happy, that's for sure." I glanced at Erica to see her open-mouthed at the exchange between Della and me. I could handle myself in these situations when I needed to. "And yes, it seems there's a lot I don't know."

Della laughed softly, the sound a melodic tease. "Perhaps, rather than saying your goodbyes as you seem intent on doing, you might find it worthwhile to stick around and explore Barnesfield a little more. I told you I'd make it worth your while if you visited."

Her implication hung between us, a tantalizing promise or a veiled threat, I couldn't be sure. But it was clear that Della played a game with rules I had yet to fully understand. As she drifted back into the crowd with a final, knowing look, I was left to ponder the depth of the waters I had waded into.

"I really don't like her," Erica growled from beside me but right then, Nancy intercepted us next, the look in her eyes cordial but with a sharpness that suggested she missed nothing.

"James, I do hope we're still expecting you for lunch tomorrow," she said, her voice smooth but commanding. "There's so much for us to talk about."

I met her gaze, aware of the layers of meaning behind her invitation. "I'll have to see how things go," I responded vaguely, unwilling to commit. Nancy nodded, though her eyes narrowed slightly, reading the hesitation in my voice.

Nancy's scrutiny intensified as she glanced from me to Erica, her lips pressing into a thin line. "James, may I have a word with you in private?" she asked.

Erica, standing beside me, stiffened slightly, her expression hardening. After a brief, tense moment, she nodded. "Of course," she said coolly, stepping back to allow us privacy but not before giving me a pointed look that said, *be careful*.

As Nancy led me a few steps away, under the pretence of needing a quieter spot, her voice dropped to a conspiratorial whisper. "You seem like a sensible man, James. I just want to ensure you're getting the right sort of guidance in this family."

"I appreciate that, Nancy," I replied, maintaining a polite facade while bracing for whatever was coming next.

Nancy's gaze was calculating as she continued, "Erica may appear charming and helpful, but don't be fooled. She's known around here for being quite manipulative... and not just with facts. She was a bad influence on Lisa, always dragging her into bad situations."

I frowned slightly, processing her words. "I see," I said noncommittally, not willing to commit to a stance without knowing more.

"And she's a bit of a tart, frankly," Nancy added, her voice dropping even lower. "I'm surprised Lisa is trusting her around you."

The accusation took me aback, but I managed to keep my expression neutral. "Thank you for the heads-up, Nancy. I'll keep it in mind."

Her response was a nod, but then she leaned in closer, her proximity uncomfortably intimate, her large breasts brushing against my arm. "You know, Erica always did have a way of stirring up trouble," she murmured, her breath warm against my ear. "And from what I've seen tonight, she hasn't changed a bit. She was always a bad influence."

Trying to keep the conversation on track, I brought up another name that had been circulating in my mind. "A bad influence? Like Sally? I was told she was a big part of Lisa's past too."

Nancy straightened up, her brow furrowing slightly. "Sally? I don't recall any Sally. Lisa didn't have many female friends apart from Erica and Joy, but maybe there was a Sally. I don't know."

Her dismissive tone suggested either ignorance or disinterest, and her proximity suddenly felt more calculated than merely intrusive. Her tits were still pressed into me. I took a step back, needing to put some physical

distance between us. “Well, thank you for your concern, Nancy. I should probably get back to saying my goodbyes now.”

Nancy’s eyes lingered on me a moment longer, her look one of appraisal before she finally stepped back, allowing me space. “Of course, James. Don’t be a stranger. We’ll see you at lunch tomorrow?”

“Perhaps,” I replied, and with a polite nod, I turned to find Erica, who was watching us from a distance with a guarded expression.

“Let me get the farewells out of the way,” I told her and then, with a last drink from the bar I barely tasted, I made my final round of pleasantries. Wishing Joy and Marcus the best felt like the only genuine interaction left, their happiness a stark island in the sea of duplicity.

As I finally rejoined Erica, the weight of the evening’s revelations and the complex web of interpersonal dynamics felt overwhelming. “Let’s get out of here,” I muttered, eager to escape the stifling atmosphere and the undercurrents of suspicion and intrigue that seemed to permeate every interaction.

Erica nodded, her earlier tension easing slightly as we made our way out of the boat club. “You okay?” she asked, her voice low.

“Just tired of games,” I admitted. “Thanks for waiting.”

As we walked back to the hotel, the night air felt thick with unspoken words. Erica broke the silence first, her curiosity clear in her tone. “What did Nancy say to you?”

I hesitated, unsure how much to share, but then decided on transparency. “She warned me about you,” I admitted, watching for her reaction. “Said you were trouble. Apparently, you’re manipulative, a bad influence and oh... she even called you a tart.”

Erica stopped in her tracks, taken aback. “She what?” Her voice rose slightly, a mix of disbelief and anger colouring her words. “That’s rich, coming from her. If the rumours are anything to go by, Nancy’s the one who’s the tart. I’ve heard she has lovers, with or without Ron’s knowledge, I don’t know. But hey, that’s just rumours,” she added quickly, her tone bitter.

“Really?” I said, also stopping as I took in this new information.

Trying to shift away from the heavy topic, Erica forced a laugh. “As I say, just rumours. Not that it’s something I’d even want to know about anyway.”

We carried on walking, the cool air rippling through her honey-coloured curls.

“Speaking of things we never wanted to know or wanted to see—Della and Wayne—that’s going to take a while to bleach from my brain,” I chuckled, trying to lighten the dark look that was on Erica’s face now.

My attempt to lift the mood made me smile, despite the turmoil. “Yeah, that was... unexpected, although she looks the sort of woman who blows guys behind boat clubs.”

I laughed. “She sure does.”

“You know, I used to have a crush on Wayne,” Erica laughed too. “But I was very young. And I definitely didn’t imagine seeing him like that, getting his dick sucked behind a bar,” she chuckled, shaking her head as if trying to dislodge the memory. “He was small too. So disappointing.”

I laughed again but then, as the conversation lulled, a question that had been nagging at me since the chat with Nancy surfaced. Something had clicked as we’d walked and I wanted to test out a theory that was forming in my brain. “Erica, about Sally... Lisa told me a lot of stories about her but Nancy says she doesn’t remember Sally. Was there ever a Sally, or am I missing something?”

Erica sighed, a long, weary sound that filled the brief silence between us. “There was no Sally, James. I’m ‘Sally.’ It was a joke, a way for Lisa to tell stories without implicating herself or me. It was stupid, I know. I shouldn’t be telling you this without checking with Lisa but you’re obviously starting to work everything out, so...”

I processed this, each piece clicking into place with a chilling clarity. “So the story about Sally and the university professor...?”

“Yes, that was me,” Erica confessed, her voice soft. “I wasn’t projected to get the grades I needed, so I took matters into my own hands. I guess Lisa isn’t the only one who made some poor choices.”

“But why? Why create Sally?” I asked, struggling to understand the need for such a facade.

“It started as a silly thing, just a way to tell wild stories from our past without it getting back to hurt anyone. But then it just... got out of hand,” Erica explained, her voice tinged with regret. “We never thought it would cause so much confusion.”

“Wow,” I found myself saying. The pieces of a puzzle I hadn’t even known I was assembling started to fall into place, each revelation reshaping

the image I had of my wife and her past. It wasn't just Lisa's secrets now; it was the realization that the fabric of these relationships was woven with deception and half-truths.

"I'm still not a tart," Erica insisted, her eyes boring into mine for a moment before she broke into a wide smile and giggled. She was incredibly attractive when she laughed. "I might have been a bit naughty, but I'm not a tart."

"Yeah, right," I chuckled, which caused her to playfully punch me in the shoulder before looping her arm through mine for the rest of the walk to the hotel.

We reached our destination, the bright hotel lobby lights feeling harsh after the dark walk. "I'm sorry, James," Erica added, turning serious again as we paused at the entrance. "I never meant for any of this to hurt you or to complicate your relationship with Lisa."

"No, it's fine," I replied, "I appreciate everything you've told me."

"I did my best to look after you today," she shrugged, the movement making her breasts bounce slightly in the low-cut dress she was wearing. "Even if it did cost me my dignity. I didn't intend for you to find out about Lisa's past... or mine."

She smiled prettily again and her proximity, the intensity of the evening, and perhaps the drinks, left me uncharacteristically bold. "You looked after me very well. And don't worry, we all have a past. Tonight has been good for one reason. I got to know you a little bit more." I found myself leaning closer, her sweet floral scent and the closeness momentarily overwhelming my better judgment. Her eyes held mine. She didn't move away.

Then, just as our faces drew perilously close, the reality of what I was doing surged back. I stepped back abruptly. "I'm sorry. What am I doing? I'm drunk, and emotional, as you said earlier."

"You are," she nodded, licking her lips but not moving.

"Thanks for everything," I added, fumbling in my pocket for the hotel key card. "It's late. Shouldn't you be heading home to your husband... or boyfriend?"

She smiled wryly, a mischievous edge to her lips for some reason. "I have a girlfriend, actually."

I blinked, surprised. "You're lesbian?"

"Not quite. I'm bisexual. I've had boyfriends; I'm slutty Sally, remember?" Her attempt at humour didn't quite mask the weariness in her

voice from explaining even more details that I didn't know. "Lisa didn't tell you—obviously—but yes, I'm with a girl right now. Her name is Beth and she's great."

"I had no idea," I replied awkwardly. "How many more surprises will this trip to Barnesfield have?"

"Hopefully not many more. Now go," she said gently, pushing against my chest with a soft hand. "Keep trying to reach your beautiful wife. You need to talk."

I nodded and turned to leave but then turned back. Her use of 'beautiful' struck a chord, a note of something unspoken yet felt between them. "Wait, you and Lisa... were you ever...?"

Erica met my gaze, her expression unreadable, and then she shrugged, a non-answer that spoke volumes. "Go, James. Call Lisa."

As she turned and walked away, the mix of her perfume and the night air lingered, leaving me with more questions than answers, and a realization that the layers of Lisa's, and now Erica's, secrets were more intertwined than I could have ever imagined.

Chapter Five

Chapter 5

Beep beep. Buzz. Beep beep. Buzz.

I reached out, groggy, to silence the blaring alarm on my phone. After fumbling to hit the 'stop' icon, I froze. The screen lit up with notifications of two missed video calls from Lisa. A sharp stab of guilt pierced me. I'd collapsed into bed last night, the alcohol muddling my senses soon after my head hit the pillow, oblivious to everything but the whirlwind of revelations and the troubling near-miss with Erica.

I swung my legs from beneath the crumpled covers and sat on the edge of the bed, cradling my slightly sore head in my hands while trying to order the chaos of my thoughts. The memory of how close I'd come to crossing a line with Erica last night bothered me. I could still feel the heat of her breath, smell the sweet floral perfume she wore, see the slight parting of her lips as I'd leaned in, driven by a weird cocktail of alcohol, confusion and desire. Fortunately, common sense had kicked in and made me pull away at the last moment but why hadn't she tried to stop me? Was it just the drink, or was there something more? The thrill of her not recoiling mixed with torment over my lack of self-control, leaving me a tangled mess of emotions.

I tried to push the thoughts from my head and picked up my phone again, thumbing through the notifications to see Lisa's smiling face frozen on the missed call screen, feeling a pang of guilt again about the lunge I'd almost made at Erica. I cursed under my breath for missing her calls. Now, more than ever, I needed to hear her voice, to reassure me that everything was okay and that I wasn't on the edge of learning something I didn't want to. I hit redial, my heart racing as I awaited the connection that would either bring relief or unleash new torrents of confusion.

As I'd feared, the phone rang out into nothingness, ending once again with the stark automated note of unavailability. Frustration knotted my stomach but just as I rose, placing the phone back down on the small wooden bedside table, it vibrated sharply, the jarring noise making my head

hurt again. I picked it up, hoping for a note from Lisa. Instead, it was a message from Wayne, penned in his usual straightforward manner, but this time, there was an unusual tone that caught my attention:

"Hope you enjoyed yesterday and that you're not too hungover. My sister, Nancy, is hosting a family dinner this afternoon and insists you join us. I have some good news to share, something I think you'll want to hear first-hand. Besides, Nancy has made quite an effort with the preparations and would feel slighted if you didn't come. It's at 1 PM. Don't disappoint us, eh?"

The message, with its blend of informal camaraderie and thinly veiled insistence, put me in a difficult position. Part of me wanted to head home and hide from what I'd learned about Nancy, but there was clearly more at stake here than a simple afternoon dinner invitation. Wayne's words, particularly the mention of 'good news' and the emphasis on not disappointing Nancy, hinted at expectation and obligation. It felt less like a casual invitation and more like a summons.

I set the phone down and took a deep breath, heading to the bathroom and splashing cold water on my face to clear my head. The thought of going to Nancy's for dinner and potentially diving deeper into the murky waters of Lisa's past felt overwhelming. I couldn't help but think about the implications of what Erica had hinted at—what might have transpired between her and Lisa. That alluring thought was tempting and yet, a part of me yearned to turn back, to retreat home, back to the simpler times before all these shadows had crept into my head. With a sigh, I decided to shower, hoping the hot water might help me clear my mind and sort through my tangled thoughts.

Even under the hot water, clarity proved elusive. The water streamed down my back, but instead of soothing, it seemed only to stir the pot of my memories and fantasies. The image of Della and Wayne together from the previous night intruded, vivid and unbidden. The sight of the attractive woman – not much older than Lisa – swallowing the much older man's cum and then her knowing smile as she looked my way replayed in my mind, igniting a strange combination of arousal and revulsion. What was her game? What did she stand to gain by flaunting her sexuality and her knowledge of Lisa so openly, so provocatively?

As the steam filled the bathroom, my thoughts veered dangerously. I found myself imagining Erica, not as I knew her, but as a young student

under the tutelage of an older, experienced professor in her 'Sally' phase. I'd seen photos of her in those years. Her blonde hair was a little longer, a little lighter. I imagined her wearing twin braids, a pair of painted-on jeans, a crop top that hugged her firm breasts and left her stomach bare—things she probably wouldn't wear these days. The fantasy of her being guided, educated in more ways than academic, stirred a primal excitement within me. The blend of guilt for my imaginings and the unresolved tension from the near-miss with Erica compounded, driving my hand onto my stiffening cock.

I leaned against the cool tiles, my breaths mingling with the steam, my hand moving almost of its own accord. The images in my head grew more vivid. I saw Della on her knees, enjoying having Wayne's stiff cock in her mouth, her cheeks caving as she sucked, drawing out her high, beautiful cheekbones. That vision twisted into younger Erica servicing a professor, her crop top gone, her naked tits capped with high, hard nipples that I'd only ever imagined. She rubbed herself through her jeans as she blew the older man in front of her. And then she was the Erica of the here and now, as I'd seen her last night, looking beautiful in her floral dress, stepping close to me, her pink lips so kissable, her body language ready to accept me. Despite my lingering headache, I came within minutes and as the water washed the sticky white cum down the drain, I finally decided which path to take.

Towelling off, I knew hiding wasn't an option. Wayne's message was a summons I couldn't ignore—not without consequences because I knew that Lisa's past would bother me until I got to the bottom of what I needed to know. As I chose my clothes, a smart shirt and trousers, I knew that, ready or not, I had to face whatever came next.

Fully dressed and somewhat resolved to what I had to do, I picked up my phone again. Tapping out a quick message, I confirmed my attendance: "I'll be there at 1 PM. Thanks for the invite." Almost immediately, Wayne replied with a terse "Great," followed by an address.

I checked out of the hotel and loaded my bag into the car. Despite the clarity of my decision to attend the dinner, a residual unease clung to me like the damp from the shower. Deciding it was wiser not to drive myself—given the possible lingering effects of last night's alcohol—I called for a taxi.

The ride was quiet, the hum of the engine and the blur of Barnesfield passing by did little to distract from my spiralling thoughts. As the taxi turned into a particularly well-maintained lane, the contrast to the earlier parts of Barnesfield I had seen was stark. We pulled up in front of a house that could only be described as a small mansion. It stood detached, with a sprawling front garden that spoke of careful tending and no small expense. The building itself boasted at least four or five bedrooms, its architecture modern and stylish, almost out of place amid the modesty of the rest of town.

I leaned forward to double-check with the driver. "Are you sure this is the address I gave you?" I asked.

"Yes, this is it," the driver confirmed without looking away from the impressive facade.

I paid and stepped out, the taxi pulling away behind me, leaving me to take in the full view of Nancy and Ron's residence. The disparity between this opulent setting and the rundown parts of Barnesfield I had witnessed was jarring. It raised more questions about the kind of lives Nancy, Wayne, and by extension, Lisa, were entwined with.

With a deep breath, I approached the ornate front door, each step echoing slightly on the well-swept pathway. My nervousness felt as heavy as the door knocker I lifted. With a resolute clack, I announced my arrival, ready, yet not entirely prepared, for whatever lay on the other side of that imposing door.

Nancy opened it before I could knock a second time, her smile as meticulously arranged as the climbing roses that framed her doorway. "James, dear, you're just in time," she greeted, her voice carrying that polished, rehearsed warmth. She was wearing an apron and I could smell the aroma of dinner cooking as soon as she swung the door open. She stepped aside, touching her dark hair, which she was wearing into a low, messy bun, and ushered me into the expansive hallway that was as immaculately decorated as the exterior promised.

The interior of the house was a study in understated elegance, the kind that spoke of old money but in the modern setting of a newly built house. As Nancy led me through to the living room, the comforting aroma of roast chicken wafted through the air, mingling with a hint of rosemary and thyme. "I'll just be a moment finishing up in the kitchen. Make yourself at home," Nancy called over her shoulder as she disappeared.

In the living room, Ron, Wayne, and Della were congregated around a low coffee table, glasses of wine in hand, seemingly relaxed and in good spirits. The two men were dressed casually, in T-shirts and jeans, so I felt overdressed in my shirt and trousers. Della, on the other hand, was wearing a dress, black and close-fitting so that it showed off her curves perfectly.

"James, good of you to join us," Wayne said, standing to offer a firm handshake. Ron nodded in greeting, a slight smile playing on his lips, while Della gave me a nod, her smile tinged with that same enigmatic quality I'd encountered before. The sight of Della triggered an unbidden and vivid flashback to the previous night's voyeuristic scene. The image of her on her knees before Wayne, her mouth hungrily sucking his small dick flashed through my mind with startling clarity, igniting a mix of discomfort and an inexplicable flicker of arousal. I blinked, forcing the vision from my head and focusing instead on the here and now.

"Thanks for having me," I managed, accepting the glass of wine Wayne offered. The room was cosy, the kind of space that was designed for comfort but also for showing off—every piece of furniture, all the artwork, seemed carefully chosen to impress. The surprise I felt at how upmarket Nancy and Ron's house made me feel uneasy. This wasn't what I was expecting.

Wayne seemed eager to lighten the mood, perhaps sensing my discomfort. "Nancy's outdone herself with the dinner, you're in for a treat," he said, a jovial tone in his voice.

"I'm looking forward to it," I replied, taking a sip of the wine and attempting a smile that felt more genuine than it probably looked. The wine was good, probably as expensive as everything else in Ron and Nancy's home. Looking for a neutral topic away from Lisa, I turned to Ron. "This is a beautiful place you have here. What work do you do to afford a house like this, if you don't mind me asking?" I asked, genuinely curious.

Ron's face lit up with pride. "I own a maritime services company with my business partner, Colin. We fix ships, basically. Actually, Colin, who also runs his own property business, built this home for us." His tone held a mix of pride and gratitude.

Just then, Nancy's voice called from the dining room, "Dinner's ready, everyone. Please, come through."

We settled around the dining table, and I did my best not to stare too openly at Nancy, who had discarded her apron. Beneath, she wore a tight

white blouse that fastened up the front, the buttons strained against her ample bust before tapering snugly against her narrow waist. Paired with a tight, khaki skirt, Lisa's aunt seemed to play the part of a sexy suburban homemaker very well. "James, did you know that Colin, who Ron was speaking about, is practically like an uncle to Lisa?" she inquired.

"No, I hadn't heard of him until today," I confessed, feeling out of my depth.

"Colin gave Lisa her first job when she was at university, working for his property business while she studied. Later on, he introduced her to Gabriella, his former business partner. When Gabriella decided to focus on developing properties abroad while Colin stayed here, Lisa went with her. She's still her boss today." Nancy clearly enjoyed telling me something I didn't know as she dished out the dinner onto the immaculate crockery laid out before us.

Of course I knew of Gabriella. I'd met her a couple of times at work events that Lisa had taken me to. Attempting to steer the conversation away from any more personal revelations, I turned to Wayne. "You mentioned there was some good news you wanted to share?"

Wayne smiled, a glint of something unreadable in his eyes. "Yes, about that..." He paused, looking around the table as if ensuring he had everyone's full attention before revealing what he had promised, then cleared his throat. "I do wish Amy and Lisa could be here to hear this. Joy, too, but she's already on her honeymoon, and Amy already knows—though I made her promise to keep it under wraps."

Before he could continue, Della, ever the centre of her own universe, chimed in, her voice tinged with excitement and nerves. "I'm pregnant," she announced, her large brown eyes sparkling as she looked around at the gathered family members.

The news momentarily silenced the room, then was met with a burst of congratulations. Ron clapped Wayne on the back, and Nancy, though looking slightly taken aback, quickly smoothed her expression into one of delight.

"Congratulations," I added, managing a sincere smile. "That's wonderful news. I'll be sure to tell Lisa as soon as I hear from her. I'm sure she'll be delighted." Inside, however, I doubted that reaction. Knowing Lisa, she would likely think it a foolish idea for Wayne to become a father again in

his sixties. The complexity of their family dynamics was already complicated enough.

Della beamed, soaking in the well-wishes, her hand instinctively resting on her stomach, which was still flat and flawless in that tight, black dress. Wayne looked equally proud and a touch overwhelmed, the significance of the moment not lost on him.

The conversation around the table shifted to baby plans and the future, a lightness permeating the atmosphere that hadn't been there before. Despite the cheerful chatter, I couldn't help but feel isolated, my thoughts drifting to Lisa. How would she handle this news? And how would this change the dynamics I was still struggling to understand?

"So when are you going to finally put a baby in my daughter?" Wayne asked, in a jocular fashion but with an unsettling bluntness. "I thought I'd be a grandfather by now, not a new father again."

"When the time is right," I shrugged. "Lisa's career is the most important thing to her right now but it's something we've spoken about for the future."

"How do you go so long without having sex?" Ron asked, digging into his chicken as though asking such a question was perfectly normal over dinner. "I can't go more than a couple of days, can I, Nance?"

"No, you can't, dear. But you still can't keep up with me." She looked at me and winked. Maybe it was the wine with dinner, but that stark, severe matron that I'd met yesterday seemed to have melted away. Or maybe I was just imagining things. "Don't ever think that as people get older, their sex drive always dips. It hasn't with this family."

"Definitely," Wayne nodded. "Look at me, with a woman half my age and still able to keep her satisfied."

"Satisfied... *and* pregnant," Della giggled, giving me a sideways look that didn't make sense until she continued. "It's actually me that has to keep up with satisfying you, Wayne."

"Oh, yeah, Della knows how to keep me happy," Lisa's father said with a dry chuckle. He shared a knowing look with his new bride.

"James, you need to get those sexy legs of Lisa's open and do what a man does," Ron pointed his fork at me. "Don't take no for an answer. Fill her pussy up more than you fill your car, that's what you need to do."

That weird joke brought a series of laughs from around the table, even from Wayne. I looked at him, wondering what kind of man would stand for his daughter being spoken about like that.

"Our sex life is fine," I responded carefully, holding back my annoyance. "I respect Lisa wanting her career first. When the time is right, we'll start a family, if that's what we both want."

"Maybe he's not got it in him," Nancy joked to her husband, the big man sitting next to her chortling at the comment.

"I've got it in me," I insisted firmly, staying calm. "I'm just not in any rush to be a father, that's all. Anyway, this chicken is lovely, Nancy. The vegetables are good too. Thank you."

"You're welcome," the imposing woman replied with a grateful smile. My attempt to change the subject worked, as Nancy began telling me her cooking secrets and how they'd been passed down from her and Wayne's grandmother but as I listened, my mind was trying to process what kind of family this was that spoke so lewdly amongst themselves and beginning to understand why Lisa had never let me spend time with them before.

This wasn't just about her past, there was more to it than that. There was something not right about this family, about this town... and one way or another, I was going to find out what it was.

Chapter Six

Chapter 6

As dinner progressed, the atmosphere at the table shifted subtly but significantly. Nancy fanned her face with her hand, seeming hot and undid the top buttons of her blouse, revealing an ample amount of cleavage. I realised she wasn't wearing a bra as the top shifted over her breasts, the shape of her nipples visible through the thin fabric. She leaned forward, fixing me with a gaze that felt too intense for casual dinner conversation. "So, James, do you like what you've seen of Barnesfield so far?" she asked, her voice a purr as she noticed my eyes unconsciously glance at the flesh on show. "There are some nicer sights away from the middle of town, you know."

Ron chimed in, perhaps to diffuse her obvious flirting or simply oblivious to it, "You should see the country club up north. Owned by Colin. Beautiful countryside there. Next time you visit, I'll take you for a drink, maybe a game of tennis."

"I don't actually play tennis," I confessed, trying to keep the conversation light. "This definitely seems like a nicer part of town. I'm sorry I haven't visited before. Lisa always seemed... reluctant to bring me here."

Nancy nodded, her eyes still locked on mine, a knowing smile playing at her lips. "That's probably because she has so much history here," she said. "She was quite the handful as a teenager—always in trouble. Lots of boyfriends, much to her poor father's distress."

Wayne, who had been mostly quiet, added with a slight frown, "She did use to be a bit of a wild one, my Lisa-bear. In fact, some might say she got herself a reputation as a slut, but she's changed her ways since moving away, hasn't she James? But, yes, that's why she always visits here without you."

The words hung in the air, heavy and uncomfortable. Everyone's eyes were on me and I shifted in my seat, feeling the conversation sliding into territory I wasn't prepared to navigate.

Della, ever the provocateur, leaned in and added, "Half the men in the club yesterday probably know Lisa better than they should."

"I don't think you should be talking about my wife like that," I replied, anger rising in my gut again, despite trying to stay cool. Had they just invited me here to insult Lisa?

"I shouldn't have said the word 'slut'," Wayne apologised quickly, perhaps sensing my darkening mood. "I'm sorry. Della, you should apologise too."

Della took her statement back too but then, Ron, seemingly trying to correct course back to polite conversation, nodded and added, "So, yes, as Wayne said, while this is the first time you've been here, Lisa visits twice a year, and she always makes excuses why you couldn't come. We know she's lying and that she just wants to keep you away because she's ashamed or whatever."

"Twice a year?" I played dumb, my mind racing. "When did she last visit?" I asked, hoping my voice didn't betray my sudden anxiety. As far as I knew, she hadn't been to Barnesfield for a lot longer time than that.

"Last time was around Easter," Ron said nonchalantly. "She always drops by then."

"That can't be," I interjected, a cold feeling settling in my stomach. That was just a couple of months ago. "She was in Bangladesh over Easter. It was her first trip there."

The big man's brow furrowed, and he shook his head. "No, she was definitely here, in Barnesfield. We all saw her, spent time with her. There are some photos... somewhere... if you want to see them."

The table went silent, the awkwardness palpable. Everyone seemed to hold their breath, waiting for someone to break the silence or to explain away the discrepancy. The implications of Ron's assertion twisted inside me—had Lisa lied about where she had been? Why would she need to, unless there was something—or someone—here she needed to keep secret from me?

"I don't think James needs to see any photos," Nancy said, breaking the silence as she stood and began to collect the empty plates and glasses.

"I'm sure there's a simple explanation," Wayne agreed, helping his sister. "Obviously, some confusion, in fact, I don't think she was here last Easter, Ron. Are you thinking about the year before?"

"Maybe I am," the big man nodded after reading the look he got from his wife before she headed into the kitchen with Wayne, both with an armful of

crockery.

Dinner finished, I excused myself from the table, claiming a need to stretch my legs after the intense and unsettling conversation, though really, I just needed a moment away to process everything. Heading towards the bathroom, the corridor felt unnervingly silent compared to the buzzing dining room.

As I was finishing up taking a pee, the door swung open abruptly. Nancy walked in nonchalantly as I was zipping up. "Nancy!" I exclaimed, startled and annoyed. "What are you doing? You can't just walk in here."

She waved off my protest with a flick of her hand, a sly smile playing on her lips. Her eyes were on my zipper as I turned around. How long had she been there and much had she seen? "Oh, come now, James. I was just checking on you. That conversation got a bit intense, didn't it? I wanted to make sure you were alright."

Although irritated by her intrusion, her presence gave me an opportunity to seek some clarifications while I had the knowledgeable woman away from everyone else. While I'd been alone in here, a recollection from last night had stirred in my mind. Specifically the name, Colin. Erica had used it when telling me the names of the two men standing behind Nancy and Ron. Two men whom she claimed Lisa had slept with.

"Nancy, yesterday at the party... I met Colin, right?" I asked, watching her reaction closely.

Her smile widened, a twinkle appearing in her eyes. "Yes, you did," she confirmed, her voice smooth, almost pleased with herself for some reason. "He was with Ron and our other friend."

"And the other guy... was his name Adam?" I continued, "Erica told me Colin and he were old friends of Lisa's."

Nancy nodded, her expression changing slightly. "Adam, yes. He's a retired university professor. Good friends with Colin and Ron. He used to teach Lisa."

The studious-looking Adam was the professor that Slutty Sally had enjoyed a fling with? I pressed further, "And Erica too, right?" I was trying to connect the dots, to understand the tangled web of relationships Erica had hinted at.

Nancy shook her head, her tone definitive. "No, that's not right. Erica never studied under Adam. It was Lisa he had under his tutelage. Perhaps Erica told you Lisa had... complications with him." She leaned in closer,

lowering her voice. "She got too involved with her professor. It's a part of her past she's not proud of. The rumours are that Adam gave her extra help... you could say, towards her degree, in return for sex"

The pieces started to fit together, though each revelation only led to more questions. "So, Lisa had an affair with her professor?" I asked, needing to hear it directly. "That's what she's been hiding from me? What she didn't want me to find out?"

Nancy's nod was slow, weighted with implication. "Yes, that's part of it. One of the reasons why she probably didn't want you digging around here. People talk, and not everyone is discreet."

As I absorbed her words, a strange mixture of emotions stirred within me. This morning, I'd fantasized about Erica fucking her professor but now I was picturing Lisa with him instead. I pushed the thoughts from my mind. The bathroom door was still ajar, and I moved to close it, needing privacy for the rest of this conversation. "And all this time... the visits, the secrets. Why hasn't anyone told me any of it until now?"

Nancy's expression softened, and she placed a hand on my arm, stroking it softly. "We all have parts of our pasts we'd rather keep buried, James, and we all thought it was for the best to leave it that way. Until now. It seems it's come time... for some reason... for you to know the truth. Which I don't like. Not one bit."

"Why?" I asked.

Nancy's white blouse really was tight, barely able to contain her large breasts. When she folded her arms, her cleavage strained at the opening further, drawing my eyes into that plush valley once again.

"Because I like my family the way it is," she smiled softly, making no attempt to cover the obscene amount of breast that I could see. "Our arrangements... the family... works as it is and I don't want that status quo to be upset by anyone – especially someone such as Erica – causing trouble."

"I don't understand," I shook my head, then realised I was staring at her breasts. I could see the edge of her areola through the gaping, flapping front of her blouse. I glanced up, forcing myself to look into that dark gaze of hers. This close, I could just make out the wrinkles around the edges of her eyes. Beneath the severity she projected, she was a beautiful, sensual woman. I immediately felt guilty for thinking it. "You should, um, fasten that up."

"Why? Am I making you flustered?" she countered. "Don't be shy. You can look if you want."

She pulled her blouse further open, so that I could almost see the entirety of her impressive breasts. I wondered if they were real. I shook my head, forcing myself to look up at her eyes and keep my gaze there.

"Nancy, this is way inappropriate," I said, as coolly as I could. "How much wine have you had?"

"Not enough," she grinned, letting her blouse fall shut and fastening her buttons yet again. "You are a pretty one, James. If I had you to myself, without Wayne and Della here... Oh, the things I'd do to you."

"I'm married," I pointed out, edging around her and making my way towards the bathroom door, "To your niece."

"I know," the older woman smiled, pushing her jet-black hair over her shoulder and smiling at me seductively, her full lips red and pouty. "It's a shame you're not more playful. With you being Lisa's husband, I'd hoped you might not take everything so seriously."

I remembered what Erica had said, about the rumours that Nancy had lovers behind Ron's back, or perhaps with his knowledge and I suspected it might be true. But I didn't understand what she meant about me *being Lisa's husband*. What was that supposed to mean?

"I'm sure Ron wouldn't like this," I added. "He's a big guy, your husband. I wouldn't want him catching me in the bathroom with his wife."

"You might be surprised about Ron." Nancy murmured as I left, walking towards the staircase. Her words continued to follow me. "He might be a big, scary guy but he's a pussycat when it comes to me getting my way."

"I bet he is," I muttered to myself as I descended the stairs. "But you're not getting your way with me."

The revelations of the afternoon made the house feel larger, colder, and more imposing than when I'd arrived. I felt out of place, a fish out of water amongst this family and Nancy's forwardness had only made me realise that even more. I collected my coat from where Nancy had hung it and poked my head through into the living room, where Wayne and Ron were sitting.

Wayne and Ron, deep in conversation by the fireplace, looked up, surprise etching their features as they saw me donning my coat. "Leaving so soon, James?" Wayne asked, his tone a mix of disappointment and concern.

"Yeah. I've got a work thing come up for tomorrow, so I have to head back. It's a long drive, and I've got to get back to the hotel first to pick the

car up," I explained, trying to keep my voice even as I made up the excuse. "I got a taxi here because my head felt a little fuzzy after last night."

"But it's clearer now?" Nancy asked, catching up after following me down the stairs.

"Things are much clearer, yes," I nodded, reading the subtext in her question, whatever it was supposed to mean.

Ron stood, crossing the room to clap me on the shoulder with a friendly but firm grip. "Well, if I can't talk you into staying, we hope to see you again soon, James. You're always welcome here, you know that."

Wayne nodded in agreement, his eyes searching mine for the real reason I was leaving. "Take care on the road, and tell my daughter to call her old dad as soon as you speak to her."

"Will do. Thanks for the dinner," I replied, managing a polite smile. "It was delicious. I really appreciate it – and the insights about Lisa's past."

With that, I left but as I reached the bottom of their long garden to wait for the taxi I'd ordered, Della appeared on the path, walking from the house towards me. As she got close, she glanced back to ensure we were alone before gesturing for me to move behind the privets, out of sight of the house.

"James," the pretty, chestnut-haired woman said quietly, her voice urgent, "There's something you should know."

I looked at her, wary after Nancy's earlier move. "What is it now, Della?"

She moved closer, her voice dropping to a whisper. "Wayne and I talked you into coming to Barnesfield for a reason and it wasn't just for Joy's wedding. The timing of that was serendipitous but there's more to it than that. Your wife... Lisa is at the centre of a complicated and dark game between people in this family and their friends."

"A game?" I frowned, tension knotting my stomach. "What kind of game?"

"I saw you and Erica behind the boat club. Did you fuck her?"

"What? No!" I shook my head vehemently.

Wayne's new wife studied me for a moment, then nodded. "Not everyone would believe you if I told them, but I won't."

"You're going to tell them that you sucked Wayne's cock behind there too? Knowing Erica and I were watching? I don't think so."

"I did that to make you realise what this family is like. They're..." Della looked around nervously before continuing, "Look. I wish I could tell you

everything, but I can't—not yet. Acting too hastily could cause... everything... to collapse like a house of cards."

I blinked. Her language, her manner, everything about Della was different. What was going on? My heart raced, "But why tell me this now? What am I supposed to do—"

"Nothing," she interrupted me, looking over her shoulder towards the house again. "Just be patient, James. Watch and listen but whatever you've heard, don't confront Lisa yet," she advised, her eyes intense. "Trust me, I'll be in touch when the time is right."

Before I could respond, the sound of the taxi honking its horn cut through the warm, late afternoon air. I turned to see the driver waving impatiently.

"I don't know what the fuck is going on, but I have to go," I said, turning back to Della. "Text me or something, when I'm back in London."

Della nodded, "I will. Be careful, James. And remember, patience."

With those parting words, I headed to the taxi, the driver's impatient gesturing hastening my steps. As I climbed into the back seat, the door closed with a definitive thud, sealing me away from Della and the cryptic warning she'd left me with.

As the taxi pulled away, I watched Nancy and Ron's house fade into the distance, their luxurious home and upmarket street replaced by the iron and metal of central Barnesfield. Pulling up to the hotel a short time later, I was still distracted by thoughts of the tangled web I was becoming increasingly caught in. The strange warning from Della, the evasive answers from Nancy, and the whole secretive atmosphere around Lisa's past left me feeling like I was missing crucial pieces of a puzzle. So, when I noticed a note fluttering under the windshield wiper of my parked car, my heart sank even deeper.

Stepping out of the taxi, I quickly grabbed the note. It was crisply folded, the handwriting firm and deliberate: "Please see the hotel receptionist immediately." No name, no further explanation. Just a command that set my nerves on edge. Had I parked illegally or something? Or had the payment not cleared?

Inside the hotel, the lobby was quiet, the dim lights casting long shadows across the polished floor. The receptionist, a young man with a polite but curious look, greeted me over the top of his thick-rimmed spectacles. "Good evening, sir. May I help you?"

I handed him the note, trying to mask the unease in my voice. "I received this on my car. I've checked out already, but it says to speak to you?"

"Oh, yes," he said, checking his computer. "It appears your room has been extended indefinitely, and it's all been paid for."

"Extended? By whom?" I asked, my mind racing with possibilities. Could it be Erica trying to help? Or was someone from Lisa's family trying to keep me here for reasons I didn't yet understand?

"I'm sorry, sir, I don't have that information. The guest arrived just before my shift started," he replied apologetically. "There's a note here that says they are waiting inside the room for you. Here's your new key card."

With a mix of trepidation and urgency, I headed to my room, key card in hand. The quiet corridors of the hotel seemed more ominous now, each step echoing louder than before. I reached my room, pausing at the door, my hand hovering over the handle. Who could be waiting inside? Erica? Somebody else tied to Lisa's obscured past?

Taking a deep breath, I opened the door slowly. The room was dimly lit by the bedside lamp, casting a soft glow over the figure lying on the bed. My heart stopped for a moment when I saw her. She looked up, her expression unreadable.

"Surprise," Lisa said softly.

Chapter Seven

Chapter 7

"Lisa... what the? How?" My voice was a mix of confusion and a faint trace of anger that she hadn't warned me of her arrival. "I've been trying to reach you in Bangladesh."

I could hardly believe this was real. As she beckoned me into the room, I studied the vision on the bed like she was a hallucination. She certainly looked like my wife. Same rounded, rosy cheeks, same pointed chin, same warm, open smile. She wore a big, fluffy hotel robe that only hinted at her creamy skin beneath.

She beckoned me into the room, her eyes searching mine. "I know, I managed to get the okay to leave early and jumped on the next flight from Dhaka. I tried video calling you last night before I got on the plane but you didn't pick up. Then I got hold of Erica and heard things might be getting a bit complicated here."

"Complicated doesn't even start to cover it," I replied, closing the door behind me and facing her fully. "I'm sorry I missed your calls, I had a bit too much to drink at the wedding and fell asleep as soon I got back."

"I've heard that too," Lisa smiled. "Erica said you both needed a few drinks to make my family bearable."

"That's true, " I replied. I walked over to the bed and sat down next to her. She smelled good, a lemony scent, no doubt her shampoo and soap from the shower she'd obviously just had. Lisa's auburn hair was still wet, tied up into a familiar twist she wore after showers. "Why didn't you call today to tell me you were coming? I've just come from your Aunt Nancy's house. They made me go for dinner."

"I didn't know if you'd gone home or not," Lisa explained, toying with her haphazard bun of raven hair. "I hedged my bets and headed here from the airport first. That way, if you were here, I could surprise you like this. And if you'd already gone home, at least I could talk to my family and see what they've told you. Assess what damage they've done."

Her smile finally slipped as she said that last part. I nodded, sighing as I shuffled closer, taking her hand in mine.

"I've learned a few things, Lisa. About you. Things I never knew, things you never told me."

Her face fell further, a shadow passing over her features. "I was going to tell you more about my past. All of it. But not until the time was right. You see, it's not just about the past; it's about now, about us."

The weight of her words hung between us, heavy with implications I was only beginning to understand. As I looked at her, the woman I loved—the woman that I'd been married to for the past five years—wrapped in mystery and secrets, a part of me wanted to turn away, forget this had ever happened and return to the bliss of ignorance back in our London home. But another part, perhaps stronger, wanted to stay, to work through this.

"Talk to me, Lisa," I said, the room closing in around us, the early evening outside fading to a distant memory. Here, now, it was just us and the truth that needed to come out.

"What do you want to know?"

"I don't know where to start," I shrugged. "Maybe... tell me about Slutty Sally first."

Lisa took a deep breath, her hands clasping and unclasping in her lap, a clear sign of her growing anxiety. "Slutty Sally was a game, James," she began, her voice a mixture of regret and defensiveness. "Erica told me you'd asked about her. Look... It was a way for Erica and me to talk about things we'd done—or wished we'd done—without it getting back to us. It was foolish, I know."

I waited, letting her gather her thoughts, knowing this was difficult for her but needing the truth more than ever.

"So, Sally is both of you?" I pressed, trying to keep my tone even, though inside, I felt like a storm was brewing. "You *and* Erica?"

"Yes, and no. Some of the stories are true, some exaggerated, and some completely made up. It was a way to cope, to laugh at things that might otherwise have been painful or embarrassing," she explained, her eyes not meeting mine.

"And Adam? The professor?" I asked, my voice hardening slightly. This part was crucial; it was the piece of the puzzle that seemed to anchor so much of the recent revelations.

Lisa's face closed off, her jaw set. "Adam was me, and he was a mistake," she admitted quietly. "I was young, impressionable, and he was... persuasive. It wasn't a fling. It was more... *coercive* than that. But it's not something I'm proud of, James."

"So it's true?" I held her gaze. "You slept with your college professor to get help with your grades? That's the story you told me about Sally."

Lisa lifted her chin defiantly, a flash of something in her eyes. Was it annoyance or a defence mechanism? "Yes," she nodded. "I was young and horny and wanted to progress. It was a mistake, I know that now, but yes, I had sex with him. A lot of sex, and do you know what? For an older guy, he was damn good."

I didn't expect the heat in her voice and the bluntness of her reply. "Wow," was all I could muster in response.

"You want honesty, James?" Lisa sat straighter, her eyes trained on mine. "Adam – and some of the other guys I went with during that time – taught me a lot. Yes, I had a few boyfriends, affairs, younger guys, older guys. I put it about a little. I enjoyed myself. I got a reputation, okay? That's why I left, but think about it this way—if I hadn't done those things, I might never have left this God-forsaken place, never moved to London and never met you."

The honesty in her voice, the clear shame, did something to temper my frustration. "But why keep this from me? Why let me find out this way?"

Lisa looked up, her jaw set again. "Because I was scared. Scared you'd see me as they do, as this... this version of me I've tried so hard to leave behind. I wanted to tell you, on my terms, in my own time. Besides, it's my past. It all happened before I met you. I could even say that it's got nothing to do with you."

"That's one way of looking at it," I replied. "Another way of looking at it is from my point of view. Having to withstand people dropping hints, playing games. Smirking at me, giving me knowing smiles and being all fucking weird. Making me feel like an idiot. In fact, your Aunt even tried it on with me this afternoon."

Lisa's eyebrows shot up, a mix of amusement and irritation flickering across her face. "Nancy tried what, exactly?" Her tone held a lightness, but her eyes were sharp, probing for details.

I shifted uncomfortably, the memory of Nancy's forwardness still vivid. "She came into the bathroom while I was in there, taking a pee. She got a

bit too close for comfort," I admitted, watching Lisa's reaction closely.

Her cupid's-bow lips thinned into a tight line for a moment before she let out a slow breath. "That sounds like Nancy," Lisa said with a sigh, her annoyance evident. "She's always been overly friendly. I'm sorry you had to deal with that."

"It was weird," I confessed, feeling relieved at sharing the discomfort with Lisa. "She was very... direct. Made some pretty suggestive comments, especially about her relationship with Ron and how he wouldn't mind."

Lisa's expression darkened slightly. "That doesn't surprise me. Nancy has always pushed the boundaries. It's her way of asserting control, I guess." She paused, her gaze settling on me with curiosity. "How did you handle it?"

"I just got out of there as quickly as I could," I said. "I told her I was married and not interested."

Lisa nodded, her hand reaching out to squeeze mine reassuringly. Her robe slipped from her shoulder, revealing one of her breasts. She didn't cover herself, a half smile tugging at the corner of her pouty lips. "Good for you. Nancy isn't the easiest person to stand up to. So what else did everyone tell you about me?"

Della's warning – to be patient and not confront Lisa yet – popped into my head then. She'd mentioned a game and Lisa being at the centre of it, but what did she mean? How much should I tell Lisa? How much should I ask her about and how much should I try to find out for myself?

"Someone told me that half the guys in the boat club, where they held the reception, had been inside you," I continued while trying to work out the best angle to take.

"I don't know exactly who was there. I'm sure that's an exaggeration. Surely, you didn't believe that, James?" Lisa raised an eyebrow, seeming disappointed in me. "They held the reception at the boat club? That makes sense, I guess." Her expression went from wistful to playful. "Hey, if you want to know something else about my past, I lost my virginity behind that place."

"Really?" I asked, the surprise evident in my voice but also a growing intrigue as I took in her candidness. It felt weird, knowing that. I wondered if she'd done it on the same spot that Della had sucked Wayne's dick. "Behind the boat club, huh?"

Lisa nodded, a mischievous glint in her eyes. "Yeah, it was with Dean, one of my first serious boyfriends. We were so reckless back then, always sneaking around, looking for places to be alone. That spot was our little secret."

"I met Dean too. Amy's half-brother," I informed her, watching her wince slightly at what she knew I was going to say next. "I never knew you'd been with a black guy."

"You never asked," she replied with an apologetic half-smile. She let the bathrobe slip from her shoulders, exposing the other breast. I'd missed those tits, the perfect swell of them, slightly more than a handful. Her dark pink nipples were erect in the cool air of the hotel room. "I had some good sex with Dean. It was a shame it didn't work out with him. He had a huge dick. The stereotypical big black cock."

Lisa liked talking dirty but I'd never heard her say anything like that before. I knew she was teasing me but I couldn't stop myself from responding. My cock was standing to attention in my trousers and somehow, Lisa knew. She reached out, feeling it through the material, stroking my erection firmly while looking into my eyes.

"What's getting you excited, James? Seeing my tits or hearing about my past?" Her hand casually loosened the belt at her waist, letting it fall open slightly so I could see a hint of her belly and lower, her inner thighs.

I swallowed hard, my throat suddenly dry. "I've missed you. But you also know how I love hearing you talk dirty. Even when it's about your past," I confessed, my voice little more than a croak. The intimate secrets she was revealing and the stirring of jealousy that I felt at her mentioning the size of Dean's penis was a strange cocktail that was unexpectedly arousing.

Lisa's smile widened as she shifted slightly, allowing the robe to part a bit more. "I'm glad," she purred. "Because there's a part of me that likes remembering those times and likes teasing you... likes knowing it excites you."

The room seemed to close in around us, the air charged with raw, palpable energy. My confession about finding her past intoxicating seemed to embolden her, and she continued.

"Do you want to hear more? About Adam, how he taught me things no one else could?" Her voice was now a deliberate tease, each word carefully weighed to draw me deeper into her little game.

I nodded, unable to find my voice, my emotions a jumble of arousal and curiosity. Lisa sat up, pulling me closer to her on the bed. Her hand found mine, guiding it to her breast, my hard-on twitching at the softness of her skin contrasting the hardness of her nipple.

"As much as it scares me to admit it, thinking about you with them... knowing how much they desired you..." I said, the words tumbling out in a rush. "Erica said something that stuck with me. She said I should be happy that you chose me when so many other men in Barnesfield wanted you."

"My friend is wise." Lisa leaned in, her breath warm against my ear as her hand sought out my cock, undoing my zipper and teasing it out so she could stroke me properly. "Let's see... What can I tell you? Adam was... experienced. He knew exactly how to touch me, where to kiss, how to make me beg for it."

"He made you beg?"

Lisa removed her robe entirely, tossing it to the floor. "He did. I did some... *very* dirty things for that man."

"Like what?"

"I'm not going to tell you everything. Not yet," she purred. She helped me out of my clothes and pushed me onto the bed, rising naked over me. Her nude body was flawless, all creamy skin and clean, sinuous curves. She knew the power her body had over me, letting me look, letting me drink her in. "He fucked me on his desk at the university. And in the lecture theatre, after hours." She ran her hand down her flat stomach, down to her moist slit. She'd shaved since our video call, her mound once again bare. "We could have been caught at any time. Similar to Dean, behind the boat house. If anyone had walked around the corner, they'd have seen everything. That kind of thing used to turn me on massively."

The imagery her words conjured was vivid and powerfully erotic, even though I was again reminded of Della giving Wayne the blowjob last night. As she continued teasing me about Dean and Adam, I found myself responding, my body tightening with need until another question came to mind. "Also, do you remember a bartender at the boat club? Tony, I think his name is."

"He still works there?" Lisa chuckled, finally straddling me and rubbing the tip of my throbbing cock against her smooth folds. "Tony was rough, passionate. Couldn't get enough of me. We'd sneak off during shifts when I worked there, quick, desperate sex in the toilets."

Her descriptions fueled my fantasies, each word adding heat to the fire building inside me. The thought of her with these men, the reality of her younger sexual freedom and exploration, was paradoxically a thrill and a cause for jealousy at the same time.

As she pushed down onto me, my cock sinking inside her, she moaned loudly. "I've missed you too." Our groins meshed and she began to ride me. "I've missed this cock."

That pushed me over the edge, I moved, rolling her onto her back and pushing her sexy legs apart, as Ron had told me to earlier.

"Come on then," she encouraged me, "Show me how much you've missed me."

I thrust my cock into her as hard and deep as I could, enjoying the grunt she made as I lifted her ankles high, pressing them back so I could go even deeper.

Fill her up more than you'd fill your car.

I tried to push Ron's voice out of my head. Then I fucked her roughly, letting out all of the tension that had built up over the past few days until eventually, my cock stiffened and I felt my seed shoot into her.

After, as we lay tangled together, the afterglow mingling with a complex cocktail of emotions, Lisa kissed my chest and looked up at me. "Does any of this change how you see me?" she asked, a hint of vulnerability in her voice.

I pulled her close, my heart swelling with an inexplicable affection and admiration for the complex, beautiful, and unabashedly sensual woman in my arms. "It changes everything," I admitted. "But only for the better. I see you, all of you, and I want us to face everything together. No more secrets, okay?"

"No more secrets," she agreed. "I'm so tired. Do you mind if I have a little sleep? I want to get ready and then call over to see Dad before it gets too late."

"Sure," I nodded. "I'll come with you."

"No," Lisa shook her head, her auburn hair wafting its lemony scent beneath my nose. "I'd rather see him on his own at first. I want to meet this Della bitch that you and Erica told me about, and I think it's best if I have a one-to-one with him about her. Is that okay?"

"Of course it is," I nodded. Perhaps that was a good idea, better than Lisa knew. It would allow Wayne to tell his daughter about her future brother or

sister himself, rather than it coming from me.

She closed her eyes and I let mine shut too. I had my Lisa back and everything was going to be okay now. I somehow just knew it.

Later, in the polished ambience of the hotel restaurant, I sat alone, swirling white wine in my glass, mulling over the whirlwind of revelations and confrontations of the past few days. Lisa had just gone to her father's house, determined to confront him about everything, leaving me to digest everything she'd told me.

Then a tall, handsome blond man entered the restaurant, his steps measured, his presence commanding immediate attention. He didn't bother introducing himself as he approached my table, his pale green eyes fixed intently on mine. "Hello, James, I come as a friend," he said, his voice calm yet imbued with an urgency that set me on edge. "I saw Lisa leave, and I thought I'd grab the chance to talk to you."

"How do you know who I am?" I asked, my brows knitting in suspicion. "Who are you?"

He ignored my question, his gaze steady as he presumptuously sat opposite me at the table. "You need to go home, James. Take Lisa and leave all of this behind before it's too late."

"Why? What are you talking about?" I demanded, my heart rate picking up and my irritation levels with it. "What is it with this place and everyone saying mysterious shit?"

"Barnesfield may look rundown and innocuous, but it holds secrets," he continued, ignoring my cursing, his voice low. "There are wealthy and powerful people here. The sort of people who can make life very difficult if you piss them off."

"Are you talking about Colin?" I pressed, trying to piece together his cryptic warnings. "Just cut with the bullshit, whoever you are and tell me what the fuck is going on."

The stranger's lips twitched in a non-committal smile. "Whatever people have told you about Lisa, and what she's told you herself, it isn't even scratching the surface. That's all I'm going to say."

Frustration surged within me. "Why? Who are you afraid of? What does this have to do with me and Lisa?"

He shook his head, glancing around as if worried about being overheard. "I can't say more for fear of repercussions. Just... if you're not going to leave, if you want to stick around, you need to start asking the difficult questions. Talk to people about Lisa who aren't her family or friends. Who aren't involved. You're a smart guy. I'm sure you can think of where to start."

Before I could probe further, he stood again, his chair scraping quietly against the floor. "Be careful, James," he added before striding away purposefully towards the exit.

Right then, the waiter brought out my food, a steaming-hot and delicious-smelling bowl of spaghetti. I thought about leaving my food behind and chasing after him, but what was the point? Everyone in this town seemed equally crazy. "Fuck this shit," I murmured to myself, tucking into the pasta.

As the stranger disappeared, I realized I never asked Lisa about the visit she allegedly made here over Easter. A few pieces were slowly coming together, each more unsettling than the last, but there were still more questions than answers. And then it hit me—where I should start. The boat club, the site of too many memories, too many secrets. Perhaps someone there could shed some light on what the hell was going on and what Della and the stranger were alluding to. I finished my spaghetti—managing for once not to get any down me—and then decided to make my first move tonight, while Lisa was preoccupied with her father and Della.

The night air was crisp as I stepped out of the foyer, my resolve hardening. Whatever lay ahead, I was ready to face it, for Lisa, for our future, and for my own peace of mind. My wife's hometown stretched out before me as I walked down the hotel steps, a deeper and darker place than I'd imagined when I first got here, but nothing was going to stop me from finding out what I needed to know.

People might see this as a game, but I wasn't going to play the fool any longer.

Afterword

Thanks for reading 'Hometown' book one. I hope you enjoyed it and that you're intrigued to see where James's journey into Lisa's past and the murky secrets of her family takes him.

It was a challenge to create an erotica piece where the wife isn't present for most of it, but all that changes as this story moves forward. What secrets does Lisa have that she'll do anything to keep hidden? What is going on with her crazy family? What did Della mean by 'games' taking place and who are the shadowy players in the background that the stranger referred to?

All will be revealed in book two, [out now!](#)

Thanks again for reading and I look forward to hearing your thoughts, feedback and other comments on my socials or my Discord channel.

Until next time, stay horny.

Paul



[Book two is out now!](#)

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About The Author

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began '*The Cuckold Collection*,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Stories*, *The Sexy Season Stories* and *The Cerulean Archives*. 2022 began two series, *Holiday Hotwives* and *A Size Queen Story* and 2023 introduced a new series, *Improper Investigations* and the return to the *Cerulean Archives* with *I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex*. 2024 sees another new series along with continuations of his current running series, the *My Wife* series and the return of *The Detective Hotwife*.

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